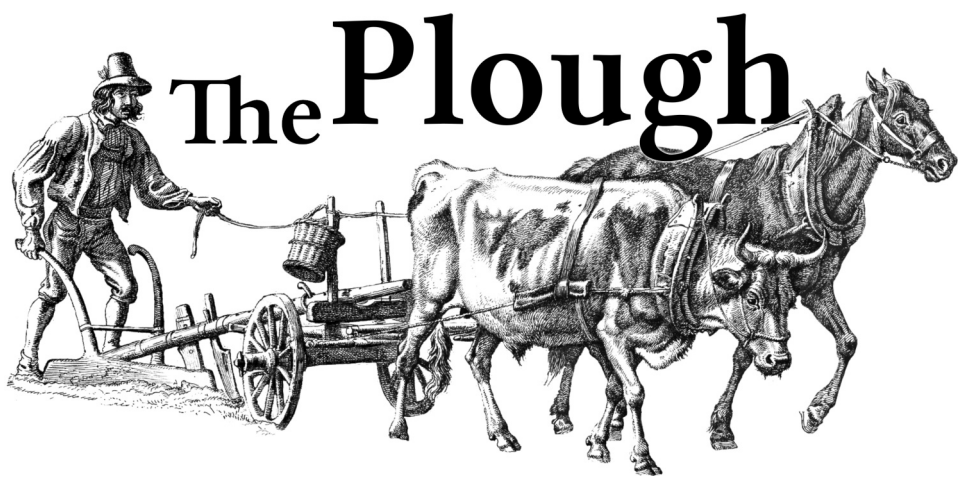




NEMO MITTENS MANUM SUAM AD ARATRUM, ET RESPICIENS RETRO, APTUS EST REGNO DEI
NO MAN PUTTING HIS HAND TO THE PLOUGH, AND LOOKING BACK, IS FIT FOR THE KINGDOM OF GOD

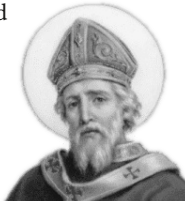
Featuring

Lives of the Saints:
St Patrick

Fr Alban Butler

The Apostle of Ireland: by one man's fidelity to his duty, a whole nation was converted for Christ. Fr Butler gives an hagiography of this great saint. May God raise up such holy bishops in our day.

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The Little Way of
Christendom: Part I

Theo Howard

Has working within the liberal system run its course? What are the fruits we have to show for our efforts? Theo Howard proposes an alternative to the rebuilding of Christendom.

pg. 8



Issue March 2026

On Ash
Wednesday

St Vincent Ferrer

The Holy Season of Lent is upon us. Let us use this time as laymen to receive all that the Church has to offer. St Vincent Ferrer gives a sermon on the purpose of Lent: repentance.

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On Christian Moral Principles Pastoral Letter of The Primate of Poland

Archbishop August Hlond

During the inter-war period, Bolshevism—a vehicle for Jewish world domination—was emboldened and unleashed. In Poland and across Europe, through subversion of the political, economic, and media institutions, a thick paralyzing smog of decay smothered the nation. Archbishop Hlond writing in 1936, entreats the Polish nation, clergy and laity alike, to uphold Catholic ethics. He further demonstrates how the natural community of the nation, imbued with supernatural grace and the teaching of the Catholic Church, is and always was the remedy against our fallen selves, and our external enemies. The Plough presents this abridged translation..

Beloved Diocesans, Moral anarchy is ravaging the world. Some non-spatial forces are breaking consciences. The Bolshevization of mentality undermines all ethical principles. Souls are becoming savage. Man is becoming animalistic. Under the guise of culture and progress, the sanitization of life is spreading.

This is happening elsewhere, and I will not tell you anything new by maintaining that it is beginning to happen here as well. It is as if some destructive demons are racing through the country, stifling the ethical sense and moral strength of the nation. Anti-church currents, subversive propaganda, and economic relations facilitate their work. The public, concerned about the intruding barbarism, defends moral health and ever more zealously guards Christian customs. But damage is being done. Consciences are becoming clouded and silenced. Honesty is shrinking. Criminality is raising its head. There are not enough schools, and prisons need to be expanded.

I would not fulfill my pastoral duty if I were to remain silent about this or obscure it. You are waiting, beloved Diocesans, for the Primate to speak out, for a word unsuppressed in any way, which would strike at the moral gangrene like a "two-edged sword." This task is to be fulfilled by this Lenten pastoral letter. Unfortunately, I am bound by the size and character of the message, and therefore I will limit myself to a few details, beginning with some remarks on the fundamental teaching of the Church on this subject.

This reminder of Catholic principles is all the more necessary because, besides the decline of morality, the propaganda of other ethical systems is increasing on the one hand, and voices about "Christian ethics" are being heard outside Catholic

circles on the other. We have a duty to separate ourselves from errors and at the same time we should remove misunderstandings. If "Christian ethics," marked in political and associative ideologies, is the same as Catholic ethics, it will find its confirmation in this letter. Otherwise, we will refer to it with due reservation.

I. From the Principles of Catholic Ethics

1. "Fear God!" This is a friendly warning against a bad deed in common life. It expresses both the Catholic instinct and the human instinct. Both link moral obligations with God. Both consider divine authority as the source and basis of ethical duty. Both appeal to God when it comes to the reason why we should do what is good and avoid what is evil.

"Fear God!" means that man must not live according to his own liking, but according to the human nature given to him by the Creator: not as if he had no soul, reason, and free will. Not like an animal lives. Not according to his whim, not exclusively for pleasure or out of habit. Everything that man consciously desires, what he consciously does and says, should correspond to the universal human principle of conduct that resides in the soul of a normal man. We call it natural law. Saint Paul writes about it that even pagans... show the work of the law written on their hearts, their consciences also bearing witness, and their thoughts sometimes accusing them and at other times even defending them (Romans 2:15).

"Fear God!" means further that a Christian, in addition to natural law, should observe revealed divine law, that is, the Decalogue and the moral principles of Christ. So a Catholic should not live as if there were no Revelation, the Ten Commandments of God, and those precepts that the divine Savior gave to redeemed humanity. Since Christ declared: I am the light of the world (John 8:12), humanity cannot ignore Christ as a legislator, and the life of Christians cannot be morally arranged without the Gospel.

"Fear God!" means that one should live as conscience dictates. And the voice of conscience, as long as it is not distorted or dimmed, is sometimes an encouragement and praise, sometimes a warning and reproach, depending on whether the deed is good or evil. This voice must not be suppressed. Woe to the man who has become deaf to the voice of conscience or bargains with his conscience. A man without a conscience is a barbarian or a madman. Catholic conscience, that "good conscience" which St. Paul often mentions,

that is, a conscience that is enlightened, correct, vigilant and free from scruples, is a reliable interpretation of moral law and a certain ethical attitude of man.

"Fear God!" finally means that every man is subject to moral responsibility for himself before God. By his own choice, man is good or evil, virtuous or depraved. By the freedom of his decision, he himself determines his value. By deciding by an act of free will such or other conduct, he is personally responsible before God for the conformity of that decision with moral law. Such is the educational sense of the Holy Scripture, that I will only cite the well-known words of Ecclesiasticus: God created man from the beginning, and left him in the hand of his own counsel; He added His laws and commandments; if thou wilt keep the commandments, and perform acceptable fidelity forever, they shall preserve thee. He has set fire and water before you; stretch out your hand for whichever you choose. Before man are life and death, good and evil; whichever he likes will be given him (Sirach 15:14-18).

2. It follows that moral law is divine law, not law created by the Church. The sole legislator and guarantor of moral law is God. The Church is not the author here, but the teacher, interpreter, and guardian.

"It is as if some destructive demons are racing through the country, stifling the ethical sense and moral strength of the nation."

The Church is there to present, proclaim, explain, and apply God's moral law to conditions and issues. The Church's mission is to demand that Catholics observe moral law. Therefore, it awakens conscience, admonishes those who err, and rebukes those who cause scandal. It is the Church's duty to guard the purity and proper adaptation of moral law in particular cases. It fulfils this with authority, gravity, and emphasis, aware of its power and mission.

A further conclusion from the above principles is that Catholic ethics is not an ethics that opposes man, degrades him, or ignores his essence. It is not an ethics that does not take into account his life's truth and real conditions, forgets about his body and organism, or quarrels with his soul and psychology. On the contrary! Catholic ethics is the ethics of the true, living, whole

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Archbishop August Hlond (1881-1948). Hlond condemned social escapism and urged the Church to confront contemporary evils.



On Christian Moral Principles Cont.

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man. It tells him to be a man where the creative will of Providence has placed him. It tells him to be the master of his own soul, the master of his own body, the master of himself. By reducing all human impulses to moral unity and harmonizing the whole human being, Catholic ethics is truly a human life orientation. It ennobles not only the external human faculties but also gives man dominion over himself, inner freedom, and responsibility for himself. It humanizes man.

Catholic ethics is always and everywhere the same inexhaustible, unyielding, uncompromising ethics. It does not recognize the fusibility of principles, nor does it allow for the flexibility of regulations. Errors sometimes occur in applying it to particular problems, but since even then the principle is not violated, sooner or later the error is recognized as an error and is corrected.

3. One who sees Catholic ethics as an ethics of prohibitions misunderstands it. While it forbids what is evil, it also commands what is good. The content of Catholic ethics is not only an alarm against falling, but also a command of moral values; not only war against sin, but also the cultivation of virtue. It therefore does not suppress values, does not impoverish, but endows. It is not a barrier in life, not a fear of decision, but an initiative for productive action. The spirit of Catholic ethics is a creative spirit, a conquering spirit, a spirit of progress and development into the infinity of divine perfection: that the man of God may be perfect, thoroughly equipped for every good work (2 Timothy 3:16). It does not narrow man in his humanity but stimulates him to mystical vitality in the supernatural world, so that man may live as a perfect man, to the measure of the full stature of Christ (Ephesians 4:13).

Nor is Catholic ethics an ethics of passivity; it is not a law of weakness or quietism, but an ethics of work, of self-control, and of struggle with oneself. At the cost of effort and struggle, all, but especially rich natures, strong and passionate individuals, achieve refinement of spirit. It is no small thing to overcome one's weakness persistently, to conquer changeability, and to master all lower impulses. It is easy

to resolve great and holy things, but to carry them out and achieve them, one must strain all the energy of the will. When temptation rages, when the inner moral bond weakens like a spider's web, when aerial flights end in descents, when conquests are followed by defeats, and after acts of heroism, a humiliating weakness of will reveals itself to man, what agonizing toil does the moral growth of man mean! With what heroic effort did the saints stand on the heights. They are true giants of will and energy, geniuses of good, the mighty elite of the human spirit, unbridled heavenly stormtroopers, God's revolutionaries among the earthly crowd!

Without activity and effort, no one will fulfil Christ's command: Therefore you shall be perfect (Matthew 5:48). We shall not be ethical because of inherited family virtues and racial impulses, because of climate and cosmic influences; we shall not be ethical because we are intelligent, lively, conquering, highly placed. We must strain our will towards the good, we must strengthen our soul with supernatural means. It is our invaluable privilege that we have at our disposal the Holy Sacraments, Holy Mass, prayers, and retreats for this purpose. How many signs indicate that we do not know how to use this privilege!

4. Finally, I would like to point out that Catholic ethics orders the individual act of man and all collective human actions. As in the life of an individual, that which is in accordance with human nature is fundamentally good, and that which is contrary to it is evil, so in collective life, the moral principle of the system and action is conformity with human nature. Catholic ethics does not incite the individual against healthy collectivity, but neither does it give the individual to the mercy of collectivity. It binds the individual to the family, to the social system, to the nation, to the state, but it protects him, demanding that in societies man remain a man and have human rights. Catholic ethics does not oppose any political form, nor does it reject any social arrangement, as long as human nature does not suffer injustice in them. Therefore, Catholic ethics is not a state system, not a social system, not an economic program, but moral principles, unchanging and eternal, which regulate both the natu-

ral rights of man in changing systems and the natural rights of collectivity to man.

Catholic ethics therefore encompasses the whole man and all human issues. It is a fundamental error to claim that Catholic ethics "has no place in the practical affairs of life." A Catholic conscience is an individual, familial, social, national, and state conscience. It reduces everything to one norm and unites everything into an ethical order, because God is not a God of discord but of peace (1 Corinthians 14:33). From one and the same conscience arise small and great deeds, hidden virtues, and decisions that determine the fate of millions. Wherever Catholic ethics are removed from collective life, licentiousness and force become law—followed by savagery and barbarism. The contemporary torments of humanity prove this conclusively.

How great, magnificent, and clear is God in establishing human moral laws! Come, let us worship and bow down, let us kneel before the Lord our Maker (Psalm 95:6). Behold, God is exalted in his power; who is a teacher like him? (Job 36:22).

II. From Our Sins

Where could I, in one reflection, go through all the areas of our life that require greater or lesser moral repair? I will confine myself to a few details, beginning with our relationship to God.

1. I have repeatedly warned you against godlessness, which is the most monstrous madness of our times. The fight against God has not eased in any way. It increases its influence year by year, and, employing the well-known tactics of anti-religious revolution, it strikes the Church and clergy with increasing passion. Where it can, it ruins the reputation of the clergy. It portrays the priest in writings and novels in an unsympathetic and repulsive manner. It judges the role of the Church in Poland critically.

This work is most evident in the intensified communist propaganda. It is increasingly cleverly masked in the performances of freethinkers. Recently, the Young Poland movement has taken it over. It works in the spirit of godlessness, setting the peasant against the priest, throwing out slogans of life without faith and God, and proposing the restoration of the cult of

"As in the life of an individual, that which is in accordance with human nature is fundamentally good, and that which is contrary to it is evil, so in collective life, the moral principle of the system and action is conformity with human nature."

Slavic deities. Its emissaries spread ordinary and Bolshevik anti-clericalism in the spirit of godlessness, recommending the replacement of Catholic ethics in the countryside with secular ethics and free customs, and often call on the peasant to radicalism and subversion.

I know that the Greater Poland countryside, striving for the full development of the people's idea, firmly opposes anti-church directions and the fight against God. The Greater Poland countryside wants rural organizational and educational activities, but activities that are in accordance with divine law; it wants a great people's movement, it demands healthy economic relations, but based on vital truth and a Catholic conscience. Do not let godlessness, anti-clericalism, and subversion into our countryside! This is bad seed, a hostile sowing, from which hatred of God and the Church is to grow. The flares announcing the mobilization of radicalism and revolution are the voices of false prophets. People's universities, educating fanatics of a godless countryside, are a great affront to the spirit and honor of the rural movement.

2. In human relations, the first divine law is love of neighbor. This law is new insofar as Christ extended it also to opponents and persecutors and commanded us to love our neighbor as ourselves. It is so fundamental that it constitutes the main basis for assessing Christianity, both individually and collectively. In this respect, today's life has great shortcomings. I will point out three details.

a) Providence has put our love of neighbor to a historic test. We are taking an exam in the presence of the all the ages of history. Our ethics and conscience are on trial as we are confronted with misery that torments millions in a terrible grip. We were accustomed to a certain prosperity and, at first, did not realize the unprecedented phenomenon of misery. It was thought that the hungry were to blame themselves, because they do not work, because they are loafers. Today, we already understand that a universal elemental dis-

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Eternally blowing with the wind!

Fort? Or Weather Vane?

Young Man of Character

Bishop Tihamer Toth

In medieval towns one can often see remnants of old fortresses. Even if most of it is in ruins, a tower still stubbornly resists the erosion of time. When these ancient towers like immovable rocks look down into the whirlwind of new life they appear to be the embodiment of character: around them everything is changing, bending, adapting, but they themselves do not compromise their principles.

This tower is the symbol of a strong character, the symbol of a man doing his duty. Just as in olden times the tower was the strongest defense of the inhabitants of the castle, now the man of character is the strongest pillar of human society. Where your calling has placed you, that is where you stay like a man, says the ancient tower. See, I have not been built in one day, I have been built from so many little

bricks and stones, with a lot of exertion, with a lot of good will, with a lot of sweat, but now here I stand unshakeable.

It is easy for our good will to slacken and wane. You often start out enthusiastically: I will start traveling the road to character, I will work hard at it, and then in just a few hours, a few days, the enthusiasm cools off, and you remained unchanged. The tower of the fort was built over years or decades, and you want to build your character in a day? But consider: the road of sin appears pleasant at first but leads to a terrible awakening; following virtue is very hard at first, but gets easier with each step, and leads to the peace of a good conscience.

But there is something on the top of the tower, something turning this way and that way—a weather vane. It has no fixed direction, it has no firm foundation; I might even say: it has no principles, it has no character. If it had, the wind would be blowing in vain. To give up

principles, to compromise convictions because it is more comfortable that way, because it will result in a better career in the world that way, because the wind is blowing that way: that is the nature of the weather vane. But do tell me, is he a man if his deeds, principles, and convictions are dictated by external circumstances and human opinions? Yet, how many such young men do you know? These are the ones who cannot stand on their own feet, who are still intellectually minors, who always ask what their neighbor might say.

His conscience says: Do not read that book, it is full of immoral filth. All right, I will not read it then. Then comes his friend: Oh, you are still a child. What? Me a child? And proceeds to read the book. And tramples his innocent soul into the mud.

His conscience says: Do not go to that play or movie, or quit that bad company. Yes, but all the others go, and all the others have a good time. Why do I have to be the exception? This is the way the weather vane thinks and acts. So which one do you want to be? Fort or weather vane? A captive of a cowardly fear of men, or a captive of your own conscience?

On Christian Moral Principles Cont.

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aster has struck us, and the unemployed and homeless are its victims. We are therefore developing organized Catholic charity, which formerly adequately provided for a small amount of poverty. We are increasing private charity. We have learned to give more than before, to give a lot. Charity has entered the household budget as a permanent and significant item. The Week of Mercy organized by “Caritas” and, most recently, the Unemployed Week in Poznań were an unprecedented success. Can we stop at that? Have we given and are we giving as much as we should? Do we love and treat this legion of the poor “as ourselves?” We are far from it. And yet, such and not another is the moral law: “as yourself.”

Already the more terrible slums of Naramowice have grown, where even in the strongholds, inhuman misery has reared itself. In the south, a proletarian “new settlement near Świerczewo” is emerging, in the north, a colony “Abyssinia” is being created near Bałtycka Avenue, etc. Under other names, in a different form and measure, every city is experiencing the same. And that quiet, unorganized, and sometimes so unlikely a misery is appearing in the countryside!

So? If this happened to us, what claims would we have against those who live a step away from a regular rhythm of modest but human existence? Would we be comforted in boundless grief by the awareness that they can and should do nothing more for us?

Love of neighbor must take on the most vital content!

b) Apart from godlessness, the greatest monstrosity of our relations is the elevation of hatred to a slogan, principle, duty. There have always been cases of hateful attitudes and hateful acts. Today, however, we are experiencing a period of glorification and canonization of hatred. Hatred is tearing societies apart. It chills the world.

Among us, hatred has mainly spread rampantly in public life. Anyone from another camp, especially a political opponent, is generally considered an enemy. No good is recognized in them, no virtues, no merits. The opponent must be evil. Lying, suspicion, and slander are used against them unscrupulously. Everything is tolerated in one’s own camp, almost everything is condemned in the opponents’. Even the possibility of agreement and cooperation is excluded. This was the case during the class struggle. All too often it happens in the struggle for power and political influence. This is sometimes the case in ordinary, non-political polemics.

Let me remind you that Catholic morality commands us to see our neighbor in every human being, despite their sins or errors. It also commands us to respect the good will, honesty, integrity, and merit in our opponent. And Christ commands us to love everyone without exception: But I say to you, Love your enemies and pray for those who persecute you, so that you may be sons of your Father who is in heaven. For he makes his sun rise on the evil and on the good, and sends rain on the just and on the unjust (Matthew 5:44-45).

But, someone will say, these people are not only evil, but decidedly harmful; after all, they must be rendered harmless. Indeed. We will consider error and falsehood as error and falsehood, crime as crime, sin as sin, perversity as perversity, apostasy as apostasy, Bolshevization as Bolshevization. We will oppose all bad propaganda. We will fight with legal means all attacks on God, faith, morality, nation, state. Let us strongly oppose Bolshevism and paganism. But, even Bolsheviks, as people and erring people, we will love and we will commend them as neighbors and brothers to God and His mercy. The Divine Heart of Jesus embraces everyone. Let us expand our small human hearts!¹

c) The Jewish problem exists and will exist as long as Jews are Jews. In the different countries, this issue has different intensity and different relevance. In our country, it is particularly difficult and should be the subject of serious consideration. Here I briefly touch on its moral side in connection with the current situation.

The fact is that Jews fight against the Catholic Church, are rooted in freethinking, and are the vanguard of godlessness, the Bolshevik movement, and subversive action. The fact is that Jewish influence on morality is pernicious, and their publishing houses promote indecency of the highest order. It is true that Jews engage in fraud, usury, and the trafficking of human beings. It is true that in schools, the influence of Jewish youth on Catholic youth is generally negative in religious and ethical terms. But—let’s be fair. Not all Jews are like that. Many Jews are honest, just in their deal-

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ings, merciful, and charitable people. In many Jewish families, the family sense is healthy and edifying. We know some people in the Jewish world who are also commendable, venerable in ethical terms.²

It is good to love one’s nation more; it is not permissible to hate anyone. Not even Jews. In commercial relations, it is good to favor one’s own before others, to avoid Jewish stores and Jewish stalls at the fair, but it is not permissible to devastate a Jewish store, destroy Jewish goods, smash windows, or throw firecrackers at their homes. One should close oneself off from harmful moral influences from Jewry, separate oneself from its anti-Christian culture, and especially boycott the Jewish press and Jewish demoralizing publications, but it is not permissible to attack Jews, beat them, injure them, or slander them. In the Jew, too, one should respect and love the human being and one’s neighbor, even if one cannot respect the

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The Father’s Role As it concerns the Catholic Mother

Anonymous Capuchin Brother

This article comes from a chapter of a book titled Mother Love, published in 1888. This title has since be republished and can be found in print today.

During the first months of its early life the child is entirely dependent upon the care of its mother. After a year or so this dependence is not so absolute, yet the child could not thrive without mother’s tender love and care. In these early years, the father would be a practical stranger to the child, unless mother roused in its little heart sentiments of love and affection for him, and this should be done from its earliest life and continued through the succeeding years, because this is of the utmost importance to the child. Neither father nor mother individually is sufficient to do justice to all the various demands of a child’s education and training, and they need each other’s cooperation in this difficult task. Mother should consider it a special favor to God to be aided in this task by the clearer judgment and the sterner determination of her husband and the father of her children, since these are a necessary supplement to her own womanly tenderness, sentiment, and affection.

Hitherto we have directed these instructions and admonitions to the mother only, but in doing so we did not intend to convey the impression as if the father were not concerned in the rearing and the training of the children; on the contrary what we have pointed out as the duties and the obligations of the mother applies just as well to the father. It is quite true that the father’s work and business do not permit as close an association with the children in their daily life, yet he

must be interested in the success of mother’s efforts and second them with the weight of his authority. In particular, the father must give his children a good example by the probity of his daily life, by regular attendance at divine services and frequent reception of the sacraments.

Harmony between father and mother is an absolute necessity in the proper rearing of the children. Father and mother must agree in the methods as well as in the means employed, so that the children may be sure that the will of the father is also the will of the mother, and the commands of the mother are also the commands of the father. The children should never be permitted to discover any difference of opinion or any discord between father and mother regarding the management of them. When a child has failed to show mother that consideration and obedience which is her due, the father should at once sharply rebuke its remissness; and if, on the other hand, it has shown any disrespect to father, the mother should at once severely reprimand it. It may happen that one of the parents has made a mistake; in this case the other one must nevertheless safeguard the authority of the mistaking one in every possible way without, however, approving the mistake. In short, the parents must appear to the child as one person, as having the same rights and authority over it, to whom it owes love, reverence, and obedience in the same degree.

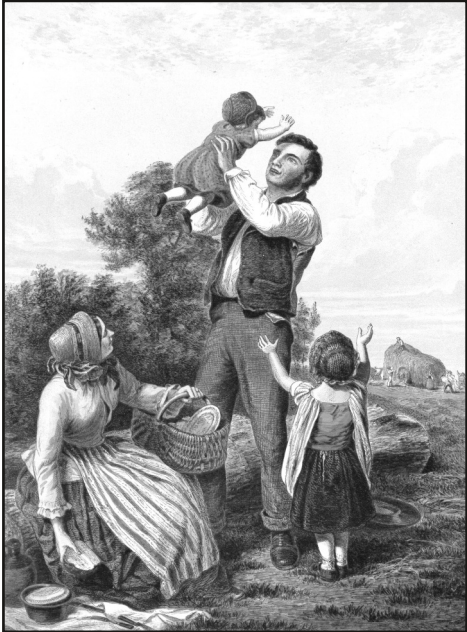
In training a child to proper respect and obedience, the mother’s example is very important. Her vocation as a wife imposes upon her the duty of respect towards her husband, because according to the doctrine of the Church, the husband is the head of the family. She must render to him submission and obedience because he is the master of the house. Mothers sometimes complain that their

children’s conduct is frequently the source of much worry and anxiety. This worry and anxiety may easily have arisen from the fact that things are topsy-turvy at home. The wife has arrogated the rights of her husband, and he, smarting under the humiliation, resents her assumption by a morose silence or, chafing under the indignity, frequently rebels against it with violent outbursts of anger. That such a condition must militate against the proper education of the children is evident. The man, indeed, may have such glaring faults as to make it rather hard to respect him, yet at the same time he has redeeming qualities. The latter good qualities and the Will of God which commands the wife to reverence her husband, should be sufficient motive to esteem him and to be obedient to him. A little good will, a generous forbearance, and a spirit of self-denial upon the wife’s part, united with earnest prayer for the help of God, will make it easy for her to submit to this fundamental principle of family government.

The father also has his obligations toward the mother of his children. He must love, honor, and respect her. He must protect her, provide for her as well as for the family, and appreciate the happiness of possessing a Christian wife who not only knows but also fulfills her duties towards him and his children and the whole household. These are the wife’s inalienable rights. Sometimes it does happen that a husband neglects these duties entirely, or is, at least, very careless about their fulfillment; sometimes he is quarrelsome, rough and uncouth, a slave of some degrading vices and habits. In God’s name, dear woman, be a heroine and stand firm in the fear and love of God; conquer him with the weapons of meekness and patience, persevere with Christ on the way of the Cross and trust to God’s mercy. A final victory may be long delayed; but there can be no doubt that at last it will be forthcoming, if mother will only persevere in the use of the means which other holy women employed for the conversion of their husbands and for their own salvation, namely, constant prayer, constant patience and humility, coupled with the tears of a loving heart. Where the

husband is lacking in fidelity to duty and is negligent in his religion, the responsibility of the mother for her children becomes doubly urgent and she should by closer watchfulness over them and by more earnest devotion to her own daily duties strive to counteract and offset the father’s bad example.

Just as the father should appreciate a faithful wife and dutiful mother as a priceless jewel, so also should the mother thank God if her husband is a prudent, alert, and industrious father, and, besides, is a truly religious man, who is faithful to his daily prayers, goes to church regularly, and receives the holy sacraments at least once a month. The fulfillment of these duties eminently fit the husband and father to be an efficient aid to a truly Christian mother in the difficult task of educating and training children for God and heaven. Therefore, Christian mother and Christian father, bear each other’s little faults and do not let the little differences of daily life disturb the sacred peace of your home.



A rich man with a sour wife can't trade all the gold in the world for the joy of a family set in order.

On Christian Moral Principles Cont.

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indescribable tragedy of this nation, which was the guardian of the messianic idea, and whose child was the Savior. And when God’s grace enlightens a Jew, and he sincerely goes to his Saviour, let us welcome him joyfully into the Christian ranks.^[^3]

Beware of those who incite anti-Jewish violence. They serve a bad cause. Do you know who tells them to do so? Do you know who benefits from these riots? A good cause gains nothing from these reckless actions. And the blood that is sometimes shed there is Polish blood.

3. Thirdly, I briefly address the ailments against the background of the seventh and tenth commandments. I do not go into the ethical principles of the social system here. God willing, I will write separately about this burning issue. Nor will I demonstrate the moral failures and sins that are caused by hunger, poverty, homelessness, and

generally the loss of those conditions in which a person feels like a normal member of society. Instead, I want to mention how dishonesty is rife among people in the ordinary conditions of existence.

Do I have to list it all? Do I have to point out these human wrongs? You know how people lie to each other. These embezzlements in banks, municipalities, offices, and enterprises are well-known. Whoever borrowed does not return, even though they can. The tenant does not pay the lease, even though they have the means. Bills are not paid in the store and at the craftsman. What’s worse. Agreements are made with the intention of not keeping them. One knowingly misleads and harms. The employer does not want to pay the employee. The worker does not work despite being paid. Wills are forged. False witnesses are bought in court. Banditry appears in villages and cities. The murmur of plunder spreads quietly.

What does all this indicate? The sense of righteousness, honesty, and justice is breaking down in consciences. A dangerous phenomenon in human coexistence! It leads to social disorder.

Beloved Diocesans! We must exert every effort to ensure that the commandment: “thou shalt not steal!” regains the power of God’s law in consciences. Honesty and integrity must be restored in life. The word “thief” should be restored to its biblical meaning. How emphatically St. Paul writes about this: Why not rather be wronged? Why not rather suffer loss? But you yourselves wrong and defraud—even your own brothers. Do you not know that the unrighteous will not inherit the kingdom of God? Do not be deceived: neither the thieves, nor the greedy,... nor the swindlers will inherit the kingdom of God (1 Corinthians 6:7-11).

4. Two years ago, in a joint pastoral letter, the Bishops warned Poland against the propaganda of freedom of morals that is inconsistent with the Ten Commandments. I must return to this topic, as an unhealthy atmosphere is thickening around us, saturated with eroticism and sensuality. Forgive me if a harsh word falls here and there.

Did not man receive from the Creator reason so as to discern what in his instincts and in their satisfaction is good and what is perverse? Does he not have free will to control what is brutal and animalistic? Is it human culture to frequent cabarets and houses of debauchery? Is it masculinity and the culture of masculinity to ensnare women, seduce other men’s wives, drive one’s wedded companion out of the house, break up peaceful families? Is it entertainment for the human spirit this licentious tone of amusements, this sensual element in modern dances, this often so unseemly social elegance?

“May every editorial office be imbued with the educational dignity of its profession to such an extent that it completely leaves the grabbing of the public with ugliness to the journalistic hooligans!”

And what to think of the attack on the soul and morals of youth? Among the most talented youths, in the name of the incontestable law of progress, the principles of unbridled enjoyment are spreading. In the psychology of the girl, the feeling of natural modesty is being fought against. What topics are discussed in youth camps? With what tendency and with what result?

If we add to this the brazenness of public demoralization, the increase in indecent publications, the degeneracy in the press, art, and literature, the vulgarization of common beaches, we will note with horror that the slogan of freedom for lust continues to wreak havoc on morals, undermines the elements of inner culture, and the ethical sense of contemporary man. Licentiousness lowers man, destroys the family, buries the nations. Strength and greatness will not spring from a decayed trunk. Debauchery kills the genius of the race.

I cannot omit the task of the press here. I do not mean writings that proclaim ethics contrary to Catholic principles or are organs of indecent publications. We should absolutely eradicate such publications as a decomposing factor. I rather mean those writings that want to be writings of a Catholic society. Is there room in them for this smearing of sensational scandals?

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The owners of a Warsaw 'theatre' in the 1920s. During the interwar period, the morals of the cities of Central Europe were degraded. A 'foreign' and 'cosmopolitan' influence abounded in media and cultural institutions. Germany faced the worst of this, particularly in Berlin. Poland received its fair share too.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR



What to give up: Candy, Soda, or the Algorithms Destroying Our World

As I continue my processes of returning to the faith I had as a child and approach the season of Lent, I am confronted by the question many toil over as their fasts approach. What should I give up? When I was a child, it was so simple to choose. I’d pick something I enjoy, like candy or soda, and boom, I’d avoid it at all costs for as long as possible before slipping an early jellybean into my mouth before Easter’s arrival. Today, I find that my approach to Lenten sacrifice is more opportunistic. As I have done in the recent past, today I find myself asking how I can change my life for the better, given the opportunity that this tradition presents to me.

Last year, I gave up YouTube for the entirety of Lent without fail. This was something that I was incredibly proud of doing, especially since I watched a considerable amount of YouTube prior to going cold turkey. While I am fortunate that YouTube is the only form of social media that has any command of my attention at all, its grasp is incredibly strong. So strong that a few days after Easter, a brief catch-up on a few channels I enjoy resulted in a full-blown relapse. A relapse that has continued to today.

This year, I intend on giving up YouTube consumption again. I have no doubt that I

will make it to Easter without it. I only fear what comes after. What will happen when the tradition that holds me accountable ends? What will keep me from knowingly wasting countless hours filling my brain with someone else’s thoughts being blasted out of a screen to avoid my own when I am tired or bored? Why do I continue to run from myself and God the second that the tradition’s season ends?

The truth is, I have used Lent as a crutch. When rejecting (or attempting to reject) the technologies we are becoming ever more attached to, Lent provides an easy and understandable excuse to others, regardless of their beliefs, of why you are not engaging in an activity that is unfortunately essential to our modern existence. After Easter, that widely accepted justification for total or partial abstinence from an omniscient computer vanishes. You are now in open rebellion against the modern world. And unlike what our modern cultural and historical mythos would suggest, rebellion is a lonely state to be in. Loneliness is the true reason I run from myself and God, the very second Lent wraps up.

For those who also find themselves viewing the approaching season of sacrifice with an opportunistic gaze, take note that this is our set of training wheels for the true sacrifice it takes to continue being present beyond Lent. During Lent,

we will draw strength from our peers who sacrifice even what we may judge as trivial attachments. When those trivial attachments return to our peers’ lives, which is within their right, we will be made aware of how close we are to falling back into our old ways.

If you are reading this and soda is truly the largest thing that is holding you back from being more present in your own life, committing to your family and peers, and exploring your faith in God, then give up soda this Lent. But if you are reading this, you are likely on a device that does far more harm to your life than soda. By no means feel that you need to live among the Amish this spring, but think about a realistic way to sacrifice something that seeks to monopolize your attention, profit from your time, and help you avoid your own thoughts.

As I give up YouTube consumption again this Lent, hopefully ridding myself of excessive consumption for good, I will also be giving up the crutch of using a seasonal justification for my rejection of the service agreement we all agree to without reading its terms everyday.

Romans 12:2 — Do not conform yourselves to this age but be transformed by the renewal of your mind.

— Mr Neo Luddy, USA.

God bless you Mr Luddy. *The Plough* aims to present edifying content for laymen in a way that negates the use of the internet. I pray that your Lent will be fruitful.

A Distributist Decrees!

I stumbled across your paper on the internet during my research on distributism and I wanted to convey that what you are doing is incredibly important. I am eager to read my first issue when it arrives. I am still finding my footing again in the Catholic Church after being away from it for quite some time, but I think it is material like this that will help engage the faithful in advocacy for an economic system that places our spirituality, humanity, and families above economic activity. God be with you and may success attend your efforts!

— Charles, USA.

Thank you Charles for your kind words. Any benefit that readers obtain from *The Plough* helps us to keep going! I will pray that Our Lord keeps you close to His Sacred Heart.

Please visit www.theplough.ink/contribute to send a letter in.



On Christian Moral Principles Cont.

Continued from Page 4

Why this initiation into the boudoir, so unrefined secrets of film stars and beauty queens. And these derailments in the fiction section, and these fatal literary criticisms, and these unfortunate surveys, and these unbelievable romance supplements! We sometimes put down the newspaper with shame and are sincerely angry with the editors for not having regard for the Catholic culture of the reader. May every editorial office be imbued with the educational dignity of its profession to such an extent that it completely leaves the grabbing of the public with ugliness to the journalistic hooligans!

Finally, a word about literature. Art in the theater, a book in the hands of society, shapes or depraves taste and conscience, even when the author does not intend it. What have not the spirits marked with the charism of inspiration given to humanity and its culture! But how terribly has literature steeped in lechery weighed on the development of the human spirit! And in Poland, writers are divided on the point of the social function of their works. Not all beautiful literature is in the service of beauty. Moral mustiness is often felt in the literary atmosphere. A terrible burden for the Polish spirit is the literature that emphasizes the sexual side of life, literature as if reserved for the negation of family virtues, divorces, adultery, shamelessness, perversions. One cannot accept literary novelties uncritically. Let us greet good works with applause. Let us absolutely turn away from our homes and libraries the rot, even if with the label of genius.

Oh, how many more sins should be mentioned! How much ethical work awaits us! How much moral repair and rebuilding!

Under the Savior's cross, in Lenten concentration, after an examination of conscience, let us beat our breasts: our fault, our fault, our very great fault. With the grace of the Holy Ghost, let us resolve on a sincere improvement and go to confession, so that, having obtained forgiveness of sins, we may completely detach ourselves from evil and resolutely end with sin. Many do not break with the evil life because they do not bring themselves to confession.

Let us pray to the Divine Heart of Jesus for contrition and a good confession for ourselves and sinners.

III. Deviations from Ethical Principles

Dear Diocesans! The last part of this letter is meant to warn you against false ethical principles. The situation more than justifies it.

1. The fundamental error of almost all ethics outside of Catholicism is a false attitude towards man. In the first part of this

letter, I pointed out that Catholic ethics are the most properly human ethics because their principle is the truth of human nature and the reality of full humanity. In this ethics, man is a true, living human being, with body and soul, with reason and will; he is both an individual and a social being, with earthly and heavenly goals, temporal and eternal. In other ethics, on the other hand, man is different, often diminished in his humanity, generally without origin from God, without afterlife destinies, without light from above, without Redemption, without supernatural life. Non-Catholic ethics 'liberate' man from dependence on God and His law, and do not recognize moral regulations associated with religion.

It would seem that ethics that omit God and Revelation should be simpler and easier, but it turns out that they are unsuitable and ruinous for man. When God ceases to be the guarantor of ethics, personal egoism, licentiousness, and group interest become the guarantor in practice. Man, cut off from eternal moral horizons, easily turns into an animal and wastes his life on barbarism.

2. For decades, materialistic ethics, to which socialism gave a class tinge, have been imposed on the world. It was born of unbelieving liberalism and ends in Bolshevism. There is no place for the soul in this ethics. It treats man unilaterally, in a typical separation from God and eternal principles. It is absolutely hostile to Catholic ethics, to revealed morality. It is an ethics of moral freedom, class hatred and struggle. However, it has failed to meet expectations because it has not created a new ethical man. It has done much damage to the conscience and life of Christian nations. For the past twenty years, Bolshevism has been brutally pushing it to its extreme conclusions. The world rightly sees in Bolshevism the ultimate and catastrophic embodiment of materialistic ethics.

3. In order not to prolong the message, I omit other ethical systems that are revered by smaller groups as a result of adopting certain association ideologies or under the aegis of sects. They generally agree on the fact that they reject Christianity and ethical revealed law. I also omit that defeatism, which is not causally related to the once fashionable moral pessimism, but has common features with it, because it undermines the life enthusiasm in the Polish soul, breaks ethical ideals, and orders one to submit to the current of life without resistance, not defending oneself against evil, not striving for a firm moral act. This is not ethics, but a convict surrender to life's effort. I immediately move on to the ethics that is most dangerous to the world at the moment, to Bolshevik ethics.

Bolshevik ethics are materialistic ethics,

brought to their last consequences and devoted to the service of the world revolution of Bolshevism. It is ethics of pure temporality, understood exclusively as a Bolshevik paradise. There is no God, religion, soul, nation, society, family, man, or human rights there—there is only Bolshevism. The benefit of the Bolshevik system is the only sacred thing and the only law. Everything is judged, undertaken, created, and destroyed in relation to Bolshevism and its prosperity. Man must cease to be man, otherwise he would not fit in Bolshevism. Therefore, no other theory has so shamelessly liberated the animal in man as Bolshevism. None has so thoroughly broken human dignity, none has so barbarically killed humanity in man. None has so perverted human nature. Only Bolshevik ethics could produce godlessness. Only Bolshevik ethics could consider it impermissible for a woman to defend herself against predators. Only in Bolshevik relations could it come to pass that, as reporters inform us, 69% of the population in the Soviets suffers from diseases with which nature itself punishes licentiousness. This is no longer ethics, but cruel, inhuman oppression.

Only Catholic ethics has elements that can effectively oppose Bolshevik ethics. There is an absolute opposite between these two ethics. Every other ethics, especially those that remove God from morality, and those that seek to appease the animal in man, cannot withstand the pressure of Bolshevik ethics, which has totally eradicated God from life and tolerates only a slave and an animal in man. Ethics wavering between Catholicism and Bolshevism will fail and succumb in the great battle for the spirit of the world. In the ideological struggle with the Bolshevik revolution, only Catholicism is unconquerable. Outside of Catholicism, Bolshevism can proclaim itself its more or less logical heir on the ruins of every ethic. This was expressed with brutal honesty by a well-known Bolshevik woman who wrote from Mexico as early as 1922: "Immorality is making comforting progress in schools. Many fifteen-year-old girls are pregnant. Let us rejoice in this, because in this way we will gain many new female communists."

This is clear. The ethics of moral freedom works for Bolshevism. Co-education that depraves, works for Bolshevism. The secular ethics of socialists, freethinkers, and Freemasons works indirectly for Bolshevism. Progressive codifications of marital law work for Bolshevism. And doesn't he who, at a meeting discussing moral issues, speaks enthusiastically, "That's how beautifully and originally it was solved in the Soviets!" also work for Bolshevism?

My dearest Diocesans! Between Catholicism and Bolshevism, between Catholic and Bolshevik ethics, a great chasm is fixed (Luke 16:26). Let's not try to baptize Bolshevism! Rather, let us defend the Polish soul from its tentacles. Let us spiritually prepare ourselves to defend Christ's moral law! Let us defend Christianity as faith and as ethics! From the spiritual struggles of the twentieth century, a new man should emerge, with unblemished humanity, with an ordered humanity, a complete, free man, with initiative, with duties and rights, united with his Creator and with the created world, united with his Redeemer and his law, united with the Holy Ghost and his grace. And therefore not a mechanical, electric, soulless robot in a world of technology transformed into a factory, but a true ruler of the world, master of himself,

"Let's not try to baptize Bolshevism! Rather, let us defend the Polish soul from its tentacles. Let us spiritually prepare ourselves to defend Christ's moral law! Let us defend Christianity as faith and as ethics!"

and servant of God.

If they have persecuted me, they will also persecute you (John 15:20). They will continue to fight against Catholic ethics as well. They will ridicule it. They will undermine it. They will spoil the reputation of Catholic virtue, saying it is insincere, artificial, covered with untruth and hypocrisy. They will accuse us of not understanding the times, of not keeping up with progress. Satires, short stories, novels will continue to present our ethics in parody. They will marvel at their often unoriginal ethical inventions, moral plagiarisms. They will discover their Catholic atavisms in themselves as if they were revelations of a new spirit!

But this will neither throw us off track nor intimidate us. We will defend Catholic ethics on every front. We will implement it in the world. We will illuminate new life issues with it. And above all, we will shape our own lives with it. Our moral example will be the most effective defense and the most convincing propaganda of Catholic ethics.

Let us repent! The historical hour for the culture of the world is striking again for our country. As a moral factor, Poland is to once again exert a prevailing influence on the spiritual direction and fate of Europe. Meanwhile, our spirit is imprisoned, as if in a besieged redoubt. We must be strong with inner strength, because we are to forge great and saving deeds, and dissolution strikes us from all sides, and fear creeps into our hearts, whether it is all a tragic illusion. For have we cemented the nation on eternal ethics? Have the foundations of statehood settled for ages on God's law?

Let us repent! Let us tear the remnants of the dust of captivity from our souls! Let us eradicate sin from Polish life!

Let us repent! Washed clean of sins by Easter confession, let us enter with our whole soul onto the path of God's commandments! Let us overcome weakness, let us drive out immorality, let us beware of empty ethics and the stain of godlessness.

Let us repent! Winged by the Spirit of Christ, rooted by the life of grace in God, let us stand for the historical spiritual reckoning with the aggressive Bolshevism! Let us prevent it from overcoming the Polish spirit!

Let us repent!

Let us beseech our most pure Queen for mighty souls, for inspired leaders, for a generation of eagles, for the heroism of action, for holiness and salvation.

1. Editor: Let us not conflate anger with hatred! Our modern sensibilities often can't separate the two. St Thomas Aquinas Summa Theologiae II-II, Q.158, A.8: "Anger may be understood in two ways. On one way, as a simple movement of the will, whereby one inflicts punishment, not through passion, but in virtue of a judgment of the reason: and thus without doubt lack of anger is a sin."

2. Editor: It is interesting to note here that Jewish converts in medieval Spain were viewed with some degree of suspicion by the Church, owing to the several cases of treachery. Archbishop Hlond recognises this, and places the caveat of the condition of sincerity to the convert. In another place, we will treat of the more recent case of the convert Fr Gregory Baum.



Polish farmers at rest. Poland was spared the worst ravages of interwar degeneracy: this was owing to a more rural population, who attached to their national traditions and the Catholic faith, couldn't be demoralised as easily as the Western European states proved to be.

What Begets Liberalism?

And Staying on Guard

Felix Sardà y Salvany

From Liberalism is a Sin. In this article, the translator of the original work in Spanish takes a certain liberty and treats of the American context.

Natural science tells us that floating through the atmosphere are innumerable disease germs seeking a suitable nest in which to settle and propagate and that we are constantly breathing these germs into the lungs. If the system be depleted or weakened, the dangerous microbe takes up its abode with us, and propagating its own kind with astonishing rapidity, undermines and ravages our health. The only safeguard against the encroachments of this insidious enemy, which we cannot escape, is a vigorous and healthy body with adequate powers of resistance to repel the invader.

It is equally true that we are subject to like infectious attacks in the spiritual order. Swarming in the atmosphere of our spiritual lives are innumerable deadly germs, ever ready to fasten upon the depleted and weakened soul and, propagating its leprous contagion through every faculty, destroy the spiritual life. Against the menace of this ever-threatening danger, whose advances we cannot avoid in our present circumstances, the ever-healthy soul alone can be prepared. To escape the contagion, the power of resistance must be equal to the emergencies of the attack, and that power will be in proportion to our spiritual health. To be prepared is to be armed, but to be prepared is not sufficient; we must possess the interior strength to throw off the germ. There must be no condition in the soul to make a suitable nest for an enemy so insidious and so efficacious as to need only the slightest point of contact whence to spread its deadly contagion.

It is not only through the avenues of disordered passions that this spiritual disease may gain an entrance; it may make its inroad through the intellect, and this under a disguise often calculated to deceive the unwary and incautious. The Trojans admitted the enemy into their walls under the impression that they were actually securing a valuable acquisition to their safety, and today their fatal experience has come down

to us in the proverb: "Beware of the Greeks when they bring gifts." Intellectual torpidity, inexperience, ignorance, indifference, and complaisance, or even virtues, such as benevolence, generosity, and pity may be the unsuspected way open to the foe, and lo, we are surprised to find him in possession of the citadel!

That we may know our danger, we must appreciate the possible shapes in which it may come. Here is just the difficulty; the uniform of the enemy is so various, changeable, sometimes even of our own colors, that if we rely upon the outward semblance alone, we shall be more often deceived than certain of his identity. But before laying down any test by which we may distinguish friend from foe in a warfare so subtly fought within the precincts of our own souls, let us first reconnoiter the respective positions of either camp, and to do this best, we shall consider the origin and sources of the danger which surrounds us, for we may be asked: "Where is this foe described as so intangible as scarcely to be apprehended by ordinary mortals?" Or it may be urged: "Is the danger as proximate, as frequent and [as] fearful as you allege? Whence is it anyhow? Point it out! If we know from what direction the enemy comes, we may better appreciate the peril."

As we are addressing ourselves to those who live amidst the peculiar circumstances of our American life, and as the spiritual and moral conditions which obtain in this country make up the moral and spiritual atmosphere in which we have our being, it is in the relation of our surroundings to ourselves as well as of ourselves to our surroundings that we shall find the answer to our question. Let us then consider these surroundings in a general way for the importance.

First, as to some patent facts: The population of this country is at present something over 260 million. Of these, 60 million are Catholics, and according to their claim, 80 million are Protestants, leaving a population of 120 million or more who do not profess any form of Christianity at all.

Among the 80 million Protestants, every

shade and variety of belief in the Christian dispensation finds easy lodgment—from the belief in the Incarnation and Consubstantiation¹ to the rejection of the divinity of Christ altogether in the vacuous creed of Unitarianism. In this scale of heresy, the adjustments of creeds are loose and easy. Lack of any decisive authority renders any exact standard of belief impossible. A Protestant may freely range from one end of the scale to the other and still be considered orthodox according to Protestant estimation. A loose, indefinite belief in Christ, either as God redeeming the world or even as a great ethical teacher (not God Himself, though sent by God), suffices to place the Protestant within the compass of his own standard of orthodoxy. Any specific expression of dogma or of particular truths bound up in the acceptance of Christianity is not required; or if required by any one sect or denomination, can find no authoritative exaction, for the differences between the sects, in the last resort, become mere differences of private opinion, dependent upon nothing but the caprice or choice of the individual.

Outside of these various bodies of loosely professed Christians stands a still larger mass of our population who are either absolutely indifferent to Christianity as a creed or positively reject it. In practice, the distinction is of little moment whether they hold themselves merely indifferent or positively hostile. In other words, we have here to reckon with a body, to all practical purposes, that is infidel. This mass comprises over 45 percent of our population, holding itself aloof from Christianity, and in some instances virulently antagonistic to it. In distinct religious opposition to this mass of infidelity and Protestantism², Catholics find themselves sharply and radically opposed. Heresy and infidelity are irreconcilable with Catholicity. "He that is not with me is against me" (Matt. 12:30) are the words of Our Lord Himself, for denial of Catholic truth is the radical and common element of both heresy and infidelity. The difference between them is merely a matter of degree. One denies less, the other more. *Protestantism, with its sliding scale of creeds, is simply an inclined plane into the abyss of positive unbelief.* It is always virtual infidelity, its final outcome open infidelity, as the 120 million unbelievers in this country stand witness.

"Intellectual torpidity, inexperience, ignorance, indifference, and complaisance, or even virtues, such as, benevolence, generosity, and pity may be the unsuspected way open to the foe, and lo, we are surprised to find him in possession of the citadel!"

We live in the midst of this religious anarchy. Some 235 million of our population can, in one sense or other, be considered anti-Catholic. *From this mass—heretical and infidel—exhales an atmosphere filled with germs poisonous and fatal to Catholic life, if permitted to take root in the Catholic heart. The mere force of gravitation, which the larger mass ever exercises upon the smaller, is a power which the most energetic vigor alone can resist.* Under this dangerous influence, a deadly inertia is apt to creep over the souls of the incautious and is only to be overcome by the liveliest exercise of Catholic faith. To live without enervation amidst an heretical and infidel population requires a robust religious constitution. And to this danger we are daily exposed, ever coming into contact in a thousand ways, in almost every relation of life, with anti-Catholic thought and customs. But outside of this spiritual inertia, our non-Catholic surroundings—a danger rather passive than active in its influence—beget a still greater menace.

It is natural that Protestantism and infidelity should find public expression. What our 200 million non-Catholic population thinks in these matters naturally seeks and finds open expression. They have their organs and their literature where we find their current opinions publicly uttered. Their views upon religion, morality, politics, the constitution of society are perpetually marshaled before us. In the pulpit and in the press they are reiterated day after day. In magazine and newspaper they constantly speak from every line. Our literature is permeated and saturated with non-Catholic dogmatism. On all sides do we find this opposing spirit. We cannot escape from it. It enfolds and embraces us. Its breath is perpetually in our faces. It enters in by eye and ear. From birth to death, it enslaves us in its offensive garments. It now soothes and flatters, now hates and curses, now threatens, now praises. *But it is most dangerous when it comes to us under the form of "liberality."* It is especially powerful for seduction in this guise. And it is under this aspect that we wish to consider it. For it is as Liberalism that Protestantism and Infidelity make their most devastating inroads upon the domain of the Faith.

Out of these non-Catholic and anti-Catholic conditions thus predominating amongst us springs this monster of our times, Liberalism!

1. The erroneous Lutheran belief that in the Eucharist the substance of the body and blood of Christ co-exist in and with the substance of the bread and wine, as opposed to the Catholic teaching of Transubstantiation, wherein the substance of the bread and wine are changed into the substance of Jesus Christ, who is thereafter present "body, blood, soul and divinity" under the appearances of bread and wine.

2. Now in excess of 76 percent of our population, but currently enhanced to an even more frightening percentage by the vast majority of Catholics today—1993—who either do not practice their faith at all or who are ignorant of its teachings (especially with regard to morality) or in practice simply disregard those teachings—bringing the total of practical non-believing and infidel people to probably just over 90 percent, if we can presume there to be today approximately 25 million believing, practicing Catholics.



Never let yourself be caught off guard! Liberalism is quite willing to play the long game, because the weariness of the battle comes to us all. Let us remain resolute, and have recourse to God to preserve us in these bellicose times.



Lives of the Saints: St Patrick

The Apostle of Ireland

Fr Alban Butler

Lives of the Saints *Benziger Brother edition 1888. Our author presents St Patrick, that holy bishop, whose feast day falls on the 17th of March.*

If the virtue of children reflects an honor on their parents, much more justly is the name of St. Patrick rendered illustrious by the innumerable lights of sanctity with which the Church of Ireland shone during many ages, and by the colonies of Saints with which it peopled many foreign countries; for, under God, its inhabitants derived from their glorious apostle the streams of that eminent sanctity by which they were long conspicuous to the whole world. St. Patrick was born towards the close of the fourth century, in a village called Bonaven Taberniæ, which seems to be the town of Kilpatrick, on the mouth of the river Clyde, in Scotland, between Dumbarton and Glasgow. He calls himself both a Briton and a Roman, or of a mixed extraction, and says his father was of a good family named Calphurnius, and a denizen of a neighboring city of the Romans, who not long after abandoned Britain, in 409. Some writers call his mother Conchessa, and say she was niece to St. Martin of Tours.

In his sixteenth year he was carried into captivity by certain barbarians, who took him into Ireland, where he was obliged to keep cattle on the mountains and in the forests, in hunger and nakedness, amidst snow, rain, and ice. Whilst he lived in this suffering condition, God had pity on his soul, and quickened him to a sense of his duty by the impulse of a strong interior grace. The young man had recourse to Him with his whole heart in fervent prayer and fasting; and from that time faith and the love of God acquired continually new strength in his tender soul. After six months spent in slavery under the same master, St. Patrick was admonished by God in a dream to return to his own country, and informed that a ship was then ready to

sail thither. He went at once to the sea-coast, though at a great distance, and found the vessel; but could not obtain his passage, probably for want of money. The Saint returned towards his hut, praying as he went; but the sailors, though pagans, called him back and took him on board. After three days' sail they made land, but wandered twenty-seven days through deserts, and were a long while distressed for want of provisions, finding nothing to eat. Patrick had often spoken to the company on the infinite power of God; they therefore asked him why he did not pray for relief. Animated by a strong faith, he assured them that if they would address themselves with their whole hearts to the true God He would hear and succor them. They did so, and on the same day met with a herd of swine. From that time provisions never failed them, till on the twenty-seventh day they came into a country that was cultivated and inhabited. Some years afterwards he was again led captive, but recovered his liberty after two months. When he was at home with his parents, God manifested to him, by divers visions, that He destined him to the great work of the conversion of Ireland. The writers of his life say that after his second captivity he travelled into Gaul and Italy, and saw St. Martin, St. Germanus of Auxerre, and Pope Celestine, and that he received his mission and the apostolical benediction from this Pope, who died in 432. It is certain that he spent many years in preparing himself for his sacred calling. Great opposition was made against his episcopal consecration and mission, both by his own relatives and by the clergy. These made him great offers in order to detain him among them, and endeavored to affright him by exaggerating the dangers to which he exposed himself amidst the enemies of the Romans and Britons, who did not know God. All these temptations threw the Saint into great perplexities; but the Lord, Whose will he consulted by earnest prayer, supported him, and he persevered in his resolution.

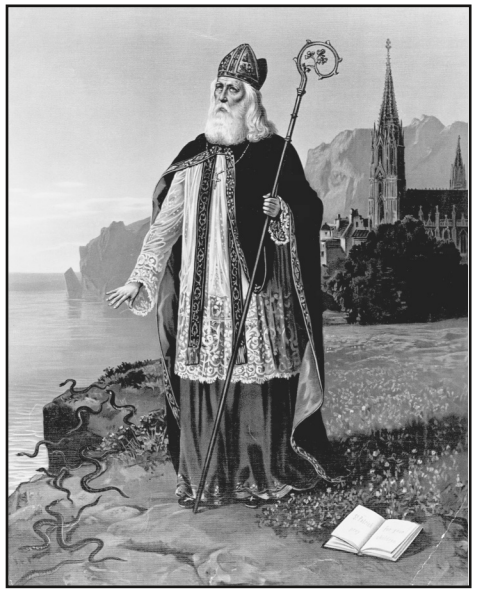
He forsook his family, sold his birthright and dignity, to serve strangers, and consecrated his soul to God, to carry His name to the ends of the earth. In this disposition he passed into Ireland, to preach the Gospel, where the worship of idols still generally reigned. He devoted himself entirely to the salvation of these barbarians. He travelled over the whole island, penetrating into the remotest corners, and such was the fruit of his preachings and sufferings that he baptized an infinite number of people. He ordained everywhere clergymen, induced women to live in holy widowhood and continence, consecrated virgins to Christ, and instituted monks. He took nothing from the many thousands whom he baptized, and often gave back the little presents which some laid on the altar, choosing rather to mortify the fervent than to scandalize the weak or the infidels. He gave freely of his own, however, both to pagans and Christians, distributed large alms to the poor in the provinces where he passed, made presents to the kings, judging that necessary for the progress of the Gospel, and maintained and educated many children, whom he trained up to serve at the altar. The happy success of his labors cost him many persecutions.

A certain prince named Corotick, a Christian in name only, disturbed the peace of his flock. This tyrant, having made a descent into Ireland, plundered the country where St. Patrick had been just conferring confirmation on a great number of neophytes, who were yet in their white garments after Baptism. Corotick massacred many, and carried away others, whom he sold to the infidel Picts or Scots. The next day the Saint sent the barbarian a letter entreating him to restore the Christian captives, and at least part of the booty he had taken, that the poor people might not perish for want, but was only answered by railleries. The Saint, therefore, wrote with his own hand a letter. In it, he styles himself a sinner and an ignorant man; he declares, nevertheless, that he is established Bishop of Ireland, and pronounces Corotick and the other parricides and accomplices separated from him and from Jesus Christ, Whose place he holds, forbidding any to eat with them, or to receive their alms, till they should have satisfied God by the tears of sincere penance, and restored the servants of Jesus Christ to their liberty. This letter expresses his most tender love for his flock, and his grief for those who had been slain, yet mingled with joy because they reign with the prophets, apostles, and martyrs. Jocelin¹ assures us that Corotick was overtaken by the divine vengeance.

St. Patrick held several councils to settle the discipline of the Church which he had planted. St. Bernard and the tradition of the country testify that St. Patrick fixed his metropolitan see at Armagh. He established some other bishops, as appears by his Council and other monuments. He not only converted the whole country by his preaching and wonderful miracles, but also cultivated this vineyard with so fruitful a benediction and increase from heaven as to render Ireland a most flourishing garden in the Church of God, and a country of Saints.

Many particulars are related of the labors of St. Patrick, which we pass over. In the first year of his mission he attempted to preach Christ in the general assembly of the kings and states of all Ireland, held yearly at Tara, the residence of the chief king, styled the monarch of the whole island, and the principal seat of the Druids, or priests, and their paganish rites. The son of Neill, the chief monarch, declared him-

“He not only converted the whole country by his preaching and wonderful miracles, but also cultivated this vineyard with so fruitful a benediction and increase from heaven as to render Ireland a most flourishing garden in the Church of God, and a country of Saints.”



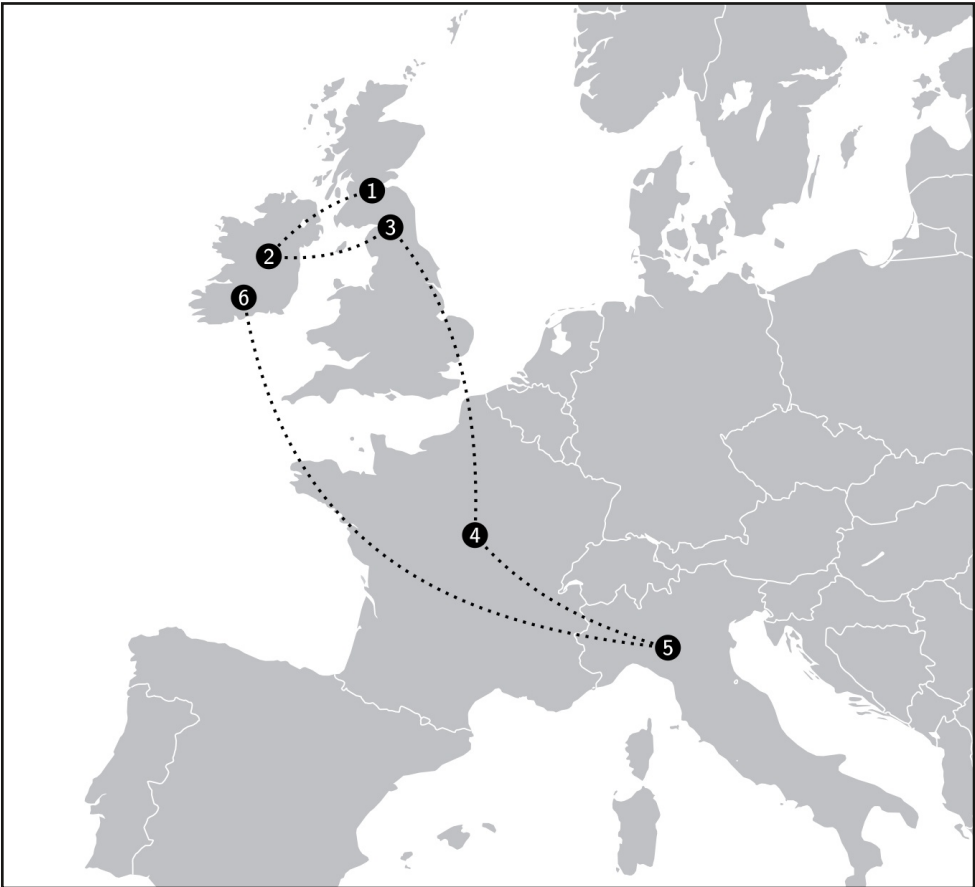
St Patrick Apostle of Ireland, pray for us!

self against the preacher; however, Patrick converted several men at the gathering. On his road to Tara, he had even converted the father of St. Benignus, his immediate successor in the see of Armagh. He afterwards converted and baptized the Kings of Dublin and Munster, and the seven sons of the king of Connaught, with the greatest part of their subjects, and before his death almost the whole island. He founded a monastery at Armagh; another called Domnach-Padraig, or Patrick's Church; also a third, named Sabhal-Padraig; and filled the country with churches and schools of piety and learning, the reputation of which, for the three succeeding centuries, drew many foreigners into Ireland. He died and was buried at Down in Ulster. His body was found there in a church of his name in 1185, and translated to another part of the same church.

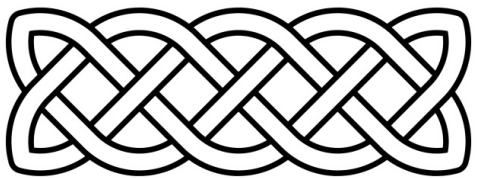
Ireland is the nursery whence St. Patrick sent forth his missionaries and teachers. Glastonbury and Lindisfarne, Ripon and Malmesbury, bear testimony to the labors of Irish priests and bishops for the conversion of England. Iona is to this day the most venerated spot in Scotland. Columban, Fiacre, Gall, and many others evangelized the “rough places” of France and Switzerland. America and Australia, in modern times, owe their Christianity to the faith and zeal of the sons and daughters of St. Patrick.

Reflection. By the instrumentality of St. Patrick the Faith is now as fresh in Ireland, even in this cold nineteenth century, as when it was first planted. Ask him to obtain for you the special grace of his children—to prefer the loss of every earthly good to the least compromise in matters of faith.

1. 12th Century Cistercian monk and hagiographer of St Patrick.



St Patrick's travels according to the hagiography of Fr Butler: 1) born in Northern Britain, 2) seized by pirates and brought to Ireland, 3) fled back to Britain, 4) travelled to the continent—this is the period considered the most difficult to chronicle, 5) eventually to Italy, 6) back to Ireland to work for its conversion.





The Little Way of Christendom: Part I

The Mission of the Laity

Mr Theo Howard

In this article, Mr. Theo Howard takes stock of the where centuries of liberalism has led us. By an honest reckoning of the situation for Catholics today, he poses the question of whether or not continued operation in the liberal paradigm is useful, and what alternatives exist for Catholic laity seeking to “restore all things in Christ.”

Modernity is inimical to Christian living and the undiluted Faith.
— Gary Potter

The Twilight of Empire

And I will give children to be their princes, and the effeminate shall rule over them.

— Isaiah 3:4

Depending on circumstance, habitual optimism can be both an American virtue and an American vice. Currently, there is a pervading atmosphere of misplaced political optimism regarding the Trump administration’s policies among many Catholics. I say misplaced, not only because of the false hope in Liberalism that it assumes and engenders, but because it distracts Catholics from taking advantage of one of the great potential benefits of the Trump administration – an afforded ‘breathing-space’ opportunity to think strategically about long-term Catholic political action.

One of the late-Bishop Williamson’s favourite phrases was: “It’s over.” As Dr Alan Fimister has pointed out, the Trump phenomenon is not a herald of recovery, much less a ‘golden age,’ it is a symptom of terminal decline. Trump has been described as a personality for the elite to ‘sell’ the diminishment of the American Empire to the population in a palatable manner.

To understand this inevitable twilight of Empire, it is helpful to consider that paradigmatic case of imperial collapse—the Fall of the (Western) Roman Empire, from the crisis of the third century through to the deposition of the last emperor in Rome in 476 AD. This complex decline can be summarised thus: fiscal and demographic implosion with chronic currency debasement and large-scale barbarian inflows. The American Empire, and the Occidental nations more broadly, clearly exhibit all four of these major horsemen of civilisational calamity.

Firstly, the demographic winter is already too late to reverse before massive architectonic forces are felt throughout the Liberal welfare states of the West. The median age of women in nearly all western

nations is now beyond child-bearing age. Even with radical pro-natalist policies of the kind proposed by conservatives who admire such incentives in Hungary, (which has only managed to raise its birth rate to 1.5 despite devoting 5.5% of GDP to family support,¹) the trend now cannot be reversed before the onset of massive systemic shocks. Of course, as Catholics we know that these afflictions are, and will be, just since they are the result of the suicidal choices that the multitude of the western populations made when they embraced the Sexual Revolution and repudiated the family as the fundamental cell of society.

It is not possible to reverse this last catastrophe [the Sexual Revolution] by legislative fiat. It requires grace and conversion and that requires a restoration of faith and discipline within the Catholic Church. Oral contraceptives created a culture of ubiquitous recreational sexual activity and this culture needs the option of murdering the products of contraceptive failure if it is not to be goaded back by nature into marriage and virtue.

— Alan Fimister²

Carl Schmitt and Karl Lowith (though occupying opposite poles of evaluation) believed that the political theology of modernity serves as a hidden legitimisation of earthly powers. Taking one data point, to understand the kratology of the modern world we might compare the relative prestige and salaries of politicians and bankers. Following the Financial Crisis of 2007-08, Anglo-German Professor Richard Werner empirically proved that, far from being merely the financial intermediaries that they present themselves as, banks do, in fact, individually create money out of nothing (which they then charge interest on).³ This institutionalised combination of usury and fraud lies at the heart of contemporary terminal western decline.

Western countries all have structural fiscal deficits, i.e., a permanent imbalance between tax revenue and government spending. These permanent deficits exist no matter how poorly, or how “well” the economy is doing.

At present, all monetary expansion required by economic expansion is carried out by bank issues of credit lent at interest... Since the burden of interest imposes repayments greater than the issues, the maintenance of economic activities needs other loans equally loaded with interest. The effect is twofold: the inflation of prices, to pay this rent for money; the accumulation of debts, industrial and

public, which are collectively unpayable.
— Felix M.^a Martin Antoniano⁴

Due to the continuous expansion of the money supply by private financial interests there is a concurrent decline in purchasing power (just like in the falling Roman Empire). This continuous currency debasement steadily erodes savings; further incentivising owners of capital to invest in assets and seek rent to protect their wealth. This dynamic has helped propel unstoppable asset price inflation and the consequent “end of ownership” that we are seeing in our time. The prospect of a hard-working family man living in modest comfort and acquiring some private property for his family is getting more and more beyond the reach of most western men. The inner logic of compound interest steadily concentrates wealth into fewer and fewer hands, while the middle and working classes suffer more and more from an increasingly unreal economy that does not guarantee the material prosperity of the nation and condemns ever-wider layers of the population to mere subsistence and debt slavery.

To come on to our fourth horseman of catastrophe: the West is not dying because it is being invaded. Rather, it is being invaded because it is dying, and because it committed suicide. Criticism of immigration has become the premier right-wing theme across the West (permitted by the Regime) and it is misplaced, not because it is *per se* wrong, but because it effeminately locates the problem in the other and discourages western man’s examination of his own sins and apostasy, thus putting off the necessary repentance. What is neglected by the “nationalist-populist” Right is the fact that our interest-bearing, debt-created fiat money system must have growth (on average, over a period) or it will collapse under the weight of the unrepayable debt. Capitalism and the fiat banking system therefore must replace non-breeding populations with immigrants, or they will die.

The American Republic will endure until the day Congress discovers that it can bribe the public with the public’s money.
— Alexis de Tocqueville

The US is on the verge of a sovereign debt crisis. At this stage, a minimum viable programme for the stabilisation of western polities, let alone their renewal, would involve western governments reversing the Sexual Revolution and ending fiat currency

“Catholics have tried this for decades, if not centuries, and it has not worked. Working within the frame of our enemies, Catholics don’t convert the Liberal system, the Liberal system converts us.”

and private credit creation. They will not do this, so, to repeat Bishop Williamson: “it’s over.” Collapse is now baked into the system.

For all of these reasons, I believe it is now past time to disabuse ourselves of misplaced optimism and any proposed courses of action which involve trying to work within Liberalism and its structures, to ‘convert it from the inside.’ Catholics have tried this for decades, if not centuries, and it has not worked. Working within the frame of our enemies, Catholics don’t convert the Liberal system, the Liberal system converts us. New ideas and new visions are needed.

Spiritually, we should not rue the collapse of such an abominable system but give glory to God for confirming His goodness by punishing the wicked and welcome the opening vistas of new possibilities that are emerging before us.

To be continued.

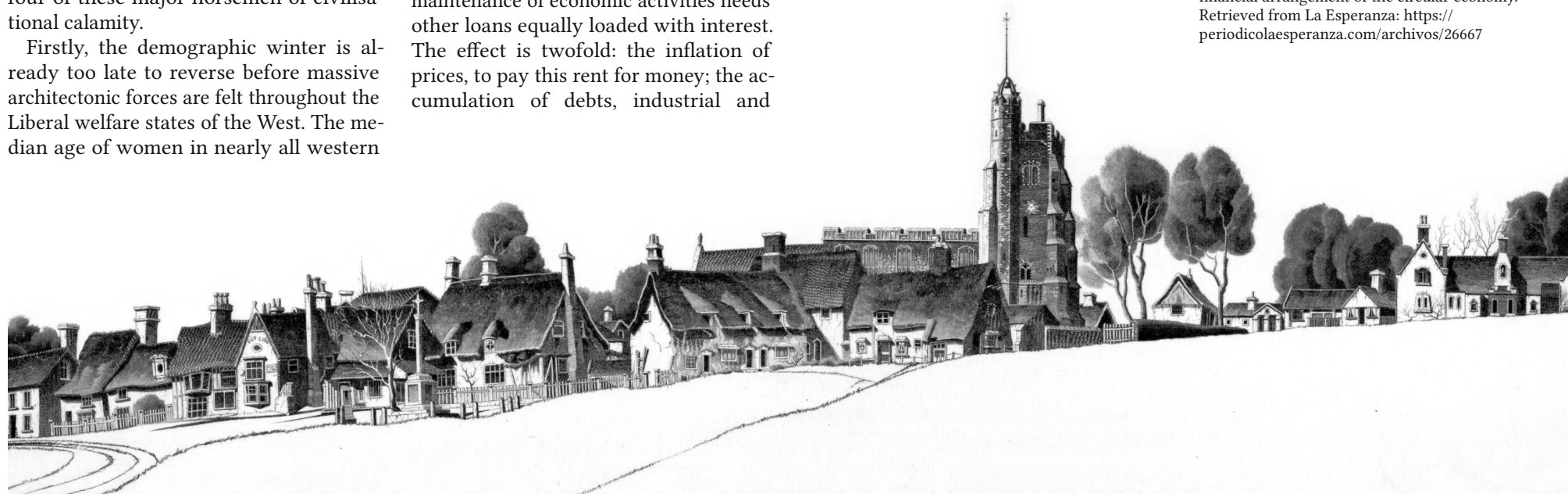
In next month’s issue, and Part II of this series, our author will guide us through an inspiring vision of an integral Catholic solution to our modern spiritual and social crises. Theo Howard is the host of The Two Cities Podcast on which he treats in a thorough and thought-provoking manner all those topics proper to the realm of the Catholic laymen. His work can be found at www.youtube.com/@thetwocitiespodcast.

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3. Werner, R. A. (2014). Can banks individually create money out of nothing? — The theories and the empirical evidence. *International Review of Financial Analysis*, 1-19. doi:<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.irfa.2014.07.015>

4. Antoniano, F. M. (2025, February 2). The correct financial arrangement of the circular economy. Retrieved from La Esperanza: <https://periodicolaesperanza.com/archivos/26667>



CROSSWORD

[illegible]

- 1) An apiarist (9)
- 6) Philosophy which denies the essences of universals and asserts that names for things are arbitrary and accidental (10)
- 8) French word for a kneeler for a single man (8)
- 9) The only gentle composer of one of the four accounts of the Holy Gospel (4)
- 10) Act whereby a spiritual creature turns from God (3)
- 11) In Shakespeare's time, a stage-man was called a 'player' rather than an _____. (5)
- 14) The instrument of the piercing of Our Lord's side (5)
- 15) Latin for 'self', or 'I' (3)
- 17) Term meaning deputy, or overseer (5)
- 19) Coming from french, meaning selection, or choice. Used to indicate that something or someone is a cut-above (5)
- 20) A type of seafaring vessel (4)
- 21) Best English translation of 'Theotokos' (6-2-3)

- 2) The kingdom of those descended from Esau (4)
- 3) Term in medicine for the treatment of a patient by the administration of inert medicine as a trick (7)
- 4) A species of cloud (6)
- 5) 17th c. spiritual classic: The Practice of the ... (8-2-3)
- 7) The term for Pope Leo XIII's policy of reconciling with the Third French Republic in the hope of converting it (10)
- 8) A ___ comes in a pod (3)
- 12) Name for a religious house for sisters or nuns (7)
- 13) The theological error of identifying creature and creator into a 'oneness'. Pantheism is a type of this. (6)
- 16) Comes in a roll, a leaf or a reem (5)
- 18) Sometimes found in swamps, other times in throats (4)

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The snow is gone from cottage tops
The thatch moss glows in brighter green
And eves in quick succession drops
Where grinning ices once hath been
Pit patting wi' a pleasant noise
In tubs set by the cottage door
And ducks and geese wi' happy joys
Douse in the yard pond brimming o'er

The sun peeps thro the window pane
Which children mark wⁱ laughing eye
And in the wet street steal again
To tell each other spring is nigh
And as young hope the past recalls
In playing groups will often draw
Building beside the sunny walls
Their spring-play-huts of sticks or straw

And oft in pleasures dreams they hie
Round homsteads by the village side
Scratting the hedgrow mosses by
Where painted pooty shells abide
Mistaking oft the ivy spray
For leaves that come w' budding spring
And wondering in their search for play
Why birds delay to build and sing

The milkmaid singing leaves her bed
As glad as happy thoughts can be
While magpies chatter o'er her head
As jocund in the change as she
Her cows around the closes stray
Nor lingering wait the foddering boy
Tossing the molehills in their play
And staring round in frolic joy

Ploughmen go whistling to their toils
And yoke again the rested plough
And mingling oer the mellow soils
Boys' shouts and whips are noising now

The shepherd now is often seen
By warm banks o'er his work to bend
Or o'er a gate or stile to lean
Chattering to a passing friend

Odd hive bees fancying winter o'er
And dreaming in their combs of spring
Creeps on the slab beside their door
And strokes its legs upon its wing
While wild ones half asleep are humming
Round snowdrop bells a feeble note
And pigeons coo of summer coming
Picking their feathers on the coat

The barking dogs by lane and wood
Drive sheep afield from foddering ground
And echo in her summer mood
Briskly mocks the cheery sound
The flocks as from a prison broke
Shake their wet fleeces in the sun
While following fast a misty smoke
Reeks from the moist grass as they run

Nor more behind his masters heels
The dog creeps o'er his winter pace
But cocks his tail and o'er the fields
Runs many a wild and random chase
Following in spite of chiding calls
The startld cat wi' harmless glee
Scaring her up the weed green walls
Or mossy mottl'd apple tree

As crows from morning perches flye
He barks and follows them in vain
E'en larks will catch his nimble eye
And off he starts and barks again
Wi' breathless haste and blinded guess
Oft following where the hare hath gone
Forgetting in his joys excess
His frolic puppy days are done

The gossips saunter in the sun
As at the spring from door to door
Of matters in the village done
And secret newssings mutterd o'er
Young girls when they each other meet
Will stand their tales of love to tell
While going on errands down the street
Or fetching water from the well

A calm of pleasure listens round
And almost whispers winter bye
While fancy dreams of summer sounds
And quiet rapture fills the eye
The sun beams on the hedges lye
The south wind murmurs summer soft
And maids hang out white clothes to dry
Around the eldern skirted croft

Each barns green thatch reeks in the sun
Its mate the happy sparrow calls
And as nest building spring begun
Peeps in the holes about the walls

The wren a sunny side the stack
Wi' short tail ever on the strunt
Cock'd gadding up above his back
Again for dancing gnats will hunt

The gladdend swine bolt from the sty
And round the yard in freedom run
Or stretching in their slumbers lye
Beside the cottage in the sun
The young horse whinneys to its mate
And sickens from the threshers door
Rubbing the straw yards banded gate
Longing for freedom on the moor

Hens leave their roosts wⁱ cackling calls
To see the barn door free from snow
And cocks flye up the mossy walls
To clap their spangld wings and crow
About the steeples sunny top
The jackdaw flocks resemble spring
And in the stone archd windows pop
Wⁱ summer noise and wanton wing

The small birds think their wants are o'er
To see the snow hills fret again
And from the barns chaff litter'd door
Betake them to the greening plain
The woodmans robin startles coy
Nor longer at his elbow comes
To peck wi' hunger's eager joy
Mong mossy stulps the litter'd crumbs

Neath hedge and walls that screen the wind
The gnats for play will Hock together
And e'en poor flies odd hopes will find
To venture in the mocking weather
From out their hiding holes again
Wi' feeble pace they often creep
Along the sun warm'd window pane
Like dreaming things that walk in sleep

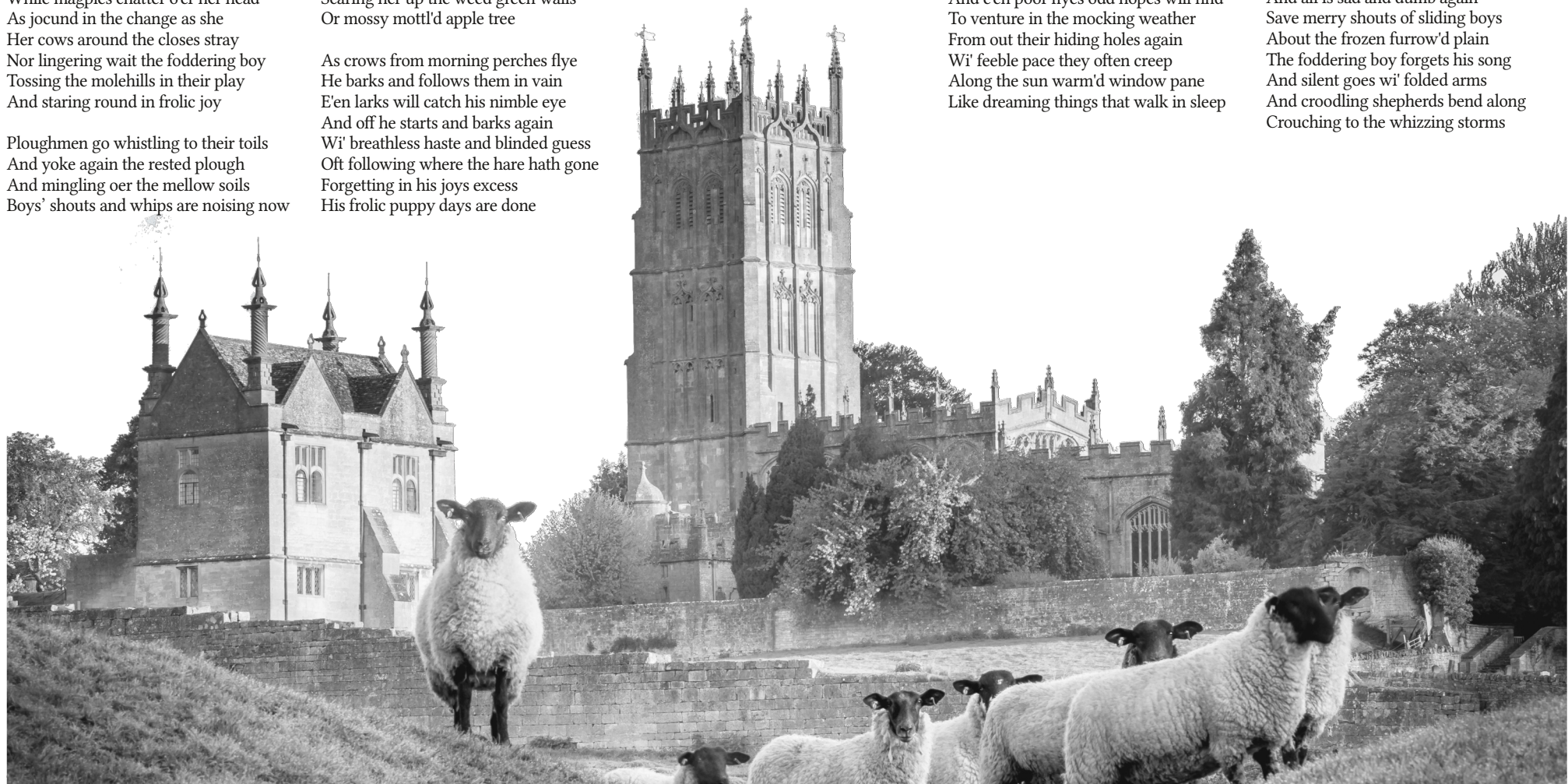
The mavis thrush wi' wild delight
Upon the orchards dripping tree
Mutters to see the day so bright
Spring scraps of young hopes poesy
And off dame stops her burring wheel
To hear the robins note once more
That tutes while he pecks his meal
From sweet briar hips beside the door

The hedgehog from its hollow root
Sees the wood moss clear of snow
And hunts each hedge for fallen fruit
Crab hip and winter bitten sloe
And oft when checked by sudden fears
As shepherd dog his haunt spies
He rolls up in a ball of spears
And all his barking rage defies

Thus nature of the spring will dream
While south winds thaw but soon again
Frost breaths upon the stiffening stream
And numbs it into ice—the plain

Soon wears its merry garb of white
And icicles that fret at noon
Will eke their icy tails at night
Beneath the chilly stars and moon

Nature soon sickens of her joys
And all is sad and dumb again
Save merry shouts of sliding boys
About the frozen furrow'd plain
The foddering boy forgets his song
And silent goes wi' folded arms
And croodling shepherds bend along
Crouching to the whizzing storms



On Ash Wednesday

Sermon of St Vincent Ferrer

St Vincent Ferrer

“And when you fast, be not as the hypocrites, sad. For they disfigure their faces, that they may appear unto men to fast. Amen I say to you, they have received their reward. But thou, when thou fastest anoint thy head, and wash thy face; That thou appear not to men to fast, but to thy Father who is in secret: and thy Father who seeth in secret, will repay thee.”

“But you, when you fast anoint your head, and wash your face...”(Mt 6:17)

That which above all in this moral life is especially necessary for us for the remission of sins and the pursuit of the kingdom of heaven, is penitence. Nor do we have any other remedy for sins committed after baptism.

Note the similarity to a sailor undergoing shipwreck, after which the sailors have no other life saver except to place themselves on some planks and firmly hang on, otherwise... So it is with us. For the Lord Jesus Christ, who is the great captain, has built a beautiful ship for sailing safely to paradise, namely baptismal innocence. And whoever rightly sails with this, like the Blessed Virgin, arrives at paradise and to its gates. Of this ship according to the spiritual sense of the [scriptural] authority, “And when he entered into the boat,” that is, baptism, his disciples, that is Christians, “followed him,” (Mt 8:23). This ship, baptismal innocence, has suffered shipwreck, and has been broken, wrecked upon the rocks of mortal sins, from the winds of diabolic temptations or the waves of carnal inclinations, or the dangers of worldly occupations, to the extent that there are so many dangers in the sea of this world that in ten thousand souls not one makes it with this ship of baptismal innocence, without sinning mortally, and so is wrecked. So, like sailors, if they are willing to cling firmly to the flotsam of penitence, they might yet survive. All the doctors say this, and the theologians, and canonists and lawyers are saying that penance is the second plank after shipwreck.

But why is it called the second plank? What is first? For an answer note that there are two shipwrecks in human nature, and the first is general, the second particular. The first shipwreck was [the loss] of original justice from the sin of Adam, for

then the ship of original justice was wrecked and all in it were drowned. Authority: “Wherefore as by one man sin entered into this world, and by sin death; and so death passed upon all men, in whom all have sinned,” (Rom. 5:12). For this reason, so that all can be saved, God ordained two planks, and the first was baptism, the second, penance. Thus penance is called the second plank. But if we wish to speak of the special or particular shipwreck, which happens when you or another sin mortally, then penance is called the first plank and not the second, because we do not have another remedy for salvation. Thus Christ said, “I say to you: but unless you shall do penance, you shall all likewise perish,” (Lk 13:3). So penance is necessary for us. In the sermon theme Christ shows us how it is to be done, saying, “when you fast, anoint... etc.”

Christ shows us three necessary things, which we should be busy about at this time, if we wish to be saved with the plank of penance. This is subtly understood in the theme.

First is penitential affliction *afflictio penitentialis*, where, “When you fast,” Second, spiritual prayer *oratio spiritualis*, where “Anoint your head.” Third is sacramental confession *confessio sacramentalis*, where, “Wash your face.”

Penance

It must be known, that Christ and holy mother the Church which orders this fast, that the fast is an affliction for those who are not accustomed to fast. I say, therefore, “when you fast,” presuming that all Christians fast, beginning today, from this day up to Easter, except for the six Sundays. And so there are forty fast days, and so by fasting we are conformed to Christ like good disciples and good ministers to our Lord, who for us fasted for forty days. Thus the Apostle, “In all things let us exhibit ourselves as the ministers of God, in much patience, ... in fastings,” (2 Cor. 6:4-5). Note the word when he says “in much patience,” because with much patience the affliction of such fasting is accomplished, by conforming ourselves to our Lord Jesus Christ. And first [patience] with ourselves, second with our neighbors, third in our own house.

First, because you are not accustomed to fast, in the beginning it is difficult for you, because the first thing in the morning your stomach growls “I’m hungry, I’m hungry, I’m hungry,” and a headache follows. Then, because you have not eaten, you find it hard to sleep, and so patience is necessary for yourself, because in this consists merit. Nor because of this should you stop fasting, remembering that Christ endured much for you, and your sins have deserved much. So, to the extent that you diligently observe a diet for your physical health, you should the more so keep the diet ordained by Christ for the health of your soul, lest it happen to you like the fearful soldiers, who in the center of the battle when they hear the cannons, are terrified and then retreat, when they should be more aggressive and fight more fiercely.

Second, it is necessary to be patient with our neighbors. For some clergy, because of their fasting, become impatient. Even when someone speaks to them politely, they react with anger. Thus patience is necessary, otherwise the fast would become diabolical, if one would fast always, but impatiently and with malice.

Third, it is necessary that you be patient in your own home. If for example, when you come home for dinner, and the dinner is not ready, you should not be indignant with your wife or family, but patiently wait and in the meantime say a prayer, and if dinner is over-cooked or less well-prepared, hold your patience and don’t throw the plate at your wife’s head. Behold why “in much patience.” Sacred scripture concurs: “For patience is necessary for you,” praying, fasting, “that, doing the will of God,” i.e. fasting, “you may receive the promise,” (Heb. 10:36). Note, “in much fastings,” namely forty days as He said.

Now there arise three questions which you commonly ask. And the first is of those saying: I have already fasted three or four Lents, or even ten, and you always are saying that Lent happens after the example of Christ who fasted only one forty-day period, why therefore, do we fast for forty days every year? Since Christ did not fast but once in his life, especially because He said, “The disciple is not above the master, nor the servant above his lord. It is enough for the disciple that he be as his master, and the servant as his lord,” (Mt 10:24f)? For the answer note that this question proceeds from the ignorance of not considering the fact of Jesus Christ. How do you believe that Christ fasted those forty days? Some simple folks would say that Christ fasted as we fast, eating once in the day etc. Others say that Christ took with him forty loaves of bread into the desert, and each day ate one. This is wrong. Some say that he was eating herbs, and this is false. Behold what the text of the gospel says. He fasted forty days in the desert, “And he ate nothing in those days”, (Lk. 3:2). Now if you wish to fast one Lent in that way, and to endure a forty day period like that, I give you permission, lest you fast any other way. For Christ, His entire life was like the Lent which we observe, because He would eat only once in the day, and nowhere do we read that He ate meat, except the paschal lamb, to fulfill the law. Because, therefore, we cannot be compared to Him in this kind of fasting; because we are not able to go for forty days without food, thus holy mother the Church in ordering our fast takes the number forty days from Christ, namely forty in general. And in a general way, from His ordinary way of living, according to the Master of History, we now receive the manner of our annual fast, namely eating only once in the day, not meat, but Lenten food, because every action of Christ is an instruction, as Gregory says. Also, “... Jesus began to do and to teach”, (Acts 1:1).

The second question is whether some are exempt from this fast? I respond that many persons are excused because neither God nor holy mother the Church intends to oblige someone to the impossible, or to put someone in danger. So you ask what kind of people are exempted? I submit that, according to the theologians, there are eight kinds of people who are dispensed from this fast.

The first exempted are pregnant women. The reason is that such women have to provide for two persons, themselves and their son or daughter. If they were to fast, the creation growing in their womb could be severely weakened and would not live long. Thus they can eat without sin. But if the woman is healthy and hearty, she can fast a little.

Second, women nursing children are excused for the same reason as above.

Third, the sick are excused, not sick of any illness whatsoever, but only of those which take away the appetite, lest they might be deprived of a good meal even once. Not [dispensed] are gout-sufferers, or the wounded nor such illnesses which do

“And so there are forty fast days, and so by fasting we are conformed to Christ like good disciples and good ministers to our Lord, who for us fasted for forty days.”

not disturb the appetite, nor those suffering from indigestion, which results from excessive food and drink etc. These do not excuse.

Fourth, the poor, who at supper time do not have enough food, like those who beg at the door or others who have nothing or barely some cabbage with oil. If such can fast, they would have great merit, but they are not obliged. About this see St Thomas [Summa] II-II q. 118. The rich, however who are able to have fish and other such foods are bound to fast.

Fifth, those journeying on foot, because of necessity; those on horseback are not excused; the horse or the mule can eat, but you can’t without sinning.

Sixth, laborers or miners, construction workers, who in whole or in part can’t, and who otherwise could not provide for their wives and children. Seamstresses however and tailors, clerks and the like who do their work sitting down are not excused.

Seventh, children. But of what age? St. Thomas in IV Sent. and in II-II, q. 147, says that not all are bound to fast. Children may even be excused, who have not yet completed 21 years. The reason, because up to that time the body is building, and children are growing. Such children need at least two meals [a day]. One for sustaining life, and the other for bodily growth. So I give you this advice for children seven or eight years old, it is enough that they fast on Good Friday. Others who are older, if eleven or twelve years old, once in the week and so on for the others.

Eighth, old folks of a certain age. When they have lost their appetite for eating or because they have lost their teeth, they should eat often or more often, like children. But old folks, eighty years old or even older, who once could eat well, are not excused in some of the above lest they sin mortally. Therefore we all should fast with diligence. Otherwise if they are not ex-

Continued on Page 11



The Temptation in the Desert (Ary Scheffer 1854)

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On Ash Wednesday Cont.



St Vincent Ferrer (1350-1419), the famous Spanish Dominican preacher. Today, he is accused by the Church's enemies of 'anti-semitism' for his zeal in converting Jews to Christ.

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cused for one of the aforesaid reasons, they sin mortally because they transgress the ecclesiastical precept. Thus the response to the second question is clear. So it is said, "And all the people cried to the Lord with great earnestness, and they humbled their souls in fastings, and prayers, both they and their wives", (Judith 4:8).

The third question posed by some, and especially by rich people, is whether they can redeem their fasting through alms, or commute their obligation, saying since there are three penitential works, namely fasting, prayer and almsgiving, and fasting is the least of the works, so these say, they may commute a lesser good into a greater good, i.e. fasting into almsgiving, and on their own, by their own authority and without permission commute their obligation to fast. The answer is no. Note, as a response, all things being equal, almsgiving is better than fasting, but on the other hand I say that obedience is better than fasting, prayer and almsgiving, "For obedience is better than sacrifices", (1 Kgs. 15). So, on this account, if you would give all that you possess in alms for the love of God, and by your own authority you break your fast, against obedience, all would be lost. Because the universal Church ordains this fast, obedience to her should be observed. So Christ says to the keepers of the Church, "He that hears you, hears me; and he that despises you, despises me", (Lk 10:16).

If therefore you have any need, you should go to the pastor, and if by chance the pastor is not certain of your need, you should consult the doctor, and if the doctor advises not to fast, with the advice and permission of the doctor and the pastor you can replace fasting with almsgiving, otherwise not.

Prayer

I say secondly, that the task which we should now be occupied and doing is spiritual prayer, when He says, "Anoint your head." And it is understood that in sacred scripture we find that Christ is the head of the Church, both militant and triumphant. The reason is because like the head, He is above and generally influences the members. St Thomas beautifully defines this in *III q. 8* and in *III Sent. dist. 13*. And the doctors in the same dist. 3. [Scriptural] authority: "And he has subjected all things

under his feet, and has made him head over all the church, which is his body", (Eph. 1:22f). Note: "all things", namely universals and particulars. Therefore the Apostle says, "But I would have you know, that the head of every man is Christ", (1 Cor. 11:3). By spiritual prayer this head, namely Christ, is anointed, which softens him and renders him gentle to sinners. You know that anointing softens and makes anointed skin smooth, although it was rough before. So Christ, to the extent that He might have seemed to be harsh and strict to sinners, by spiritual prayer is rendered soft and gentle. St Bernard: "Prayer anoints God, tears pierce him." And so the Lord Jesus Christ, who in His fleshly time, is hard and strict because of our sins, and through the rigor of His justice, if now in this holy time is anointed with devout prayers, He becomes gentle and soft. And by this oil He wishes to be anointed, because it pleases Him much. And note this parable which He told about himself: "Therefore is the kingdom of heaven likened to a king, who would take an account of his servants. And when he had begun to take the account, one was brought to him, that owed him ten thousand talents. And as he had not wherewith to pay it, his lord commanded that he should be sold", (Mt 18:23-25). That worthless servant began to anoint his head with the oil of prayer saying, "Have patience with me, and I will pay thee all,"

"And the lord of that servant being moved with pity, let him go and forgave him the debt. But when that servant was gone out, he found one of his fellow servants that owed him an hundred pence: and laying hold of him, throttled him, saying: Pay what thou owest. And his fellow servant falling down, besought him, saying: Have patience with me, and I will pay thee all. And he would not: but went and cast him into prison, till he paid the debt. Now his fellow servants seeing what was done, were very much grieved, and they came and told their lord all that was done. Then his lord called him; and said to him: Thou wicked servant, I forgave thee all the debt, because you asked me."

In this parable Christ is speaking about Himself, who is the Lord and our King. We are the servants and must render to Him an account, how we have dealt with thoughts, words, deeds and all are obligated to "ten thousand," which ten are the commandments in which are included all the perfections of this life. We by sinning are obliged to satisfaction. If therefore you wish that your debt be dismissed to you, anoint His head, namely of Christ. If you wish to know the manner of anointing, look to Mary Magdalen, about whom it is said, "There came to him a woman having an alabaster box of precious ointment, and poured it on his head as he was at table", (Mt 20:7).

Here is shown three ways for those who are serving in devout prayer:

The first way is when the scripture says "There came to him a woman," that is, a devout soul, thinking devoutly when one is saying when He says "Our Father who art etc..."

The second way is when it is said "having an alabaster box", that is a body of precious ointment, namely reverential fear.

The third way is where it says "and poured it on his head", and this is when the mouth is opened, saying devoutly the words of a prayer. And just as Mary Mag-

dalene twice anointed Christ, so you twice a day ought to anoint Christ, devoutly praying, in the morning and in the evening. Behold therefore why He says, "Anoint your head, etc." And this for the second part.

Confession

Third: I say that the third work which we should occupy ourselves in this holy time is sacramental confession, when He says, "and wash your face, etc." Conscience is the face of the soul. Reason: Because just as in the face we recognize the person, so God in the face recognizes who are His disciples. And of this face David speaks saying in Psalm 26:8, "My heart has spoken to you, my face has sought you", that is, the conscience. This face is washed now through sacramental confession. O who washes the face of his body only once a year? How much dirt and grime would it have! So it is of the face of conscience. This washing was prefigured in 4 Kgs. 4:5, where God prefigured the necessity of confession in the leper Naaman. And note, briefly the story when Elisha the prophet said, "Go, and wash seven times in the Jordan, and thy flesh shall recover health, and you shall be clean." Note that leprosy stands for mortal sin. And note, that the leper has the effects of every mortal sin. First, because the leprosy makes a man swell. See here the effects of the sin of pride. Second, it induces a great thirst, through which is symbolized the sin of avarice. Third, it infects those living with him. Behold the effects of the sin of lust. Fourth, it dehydrates. Behold here, envy. Fifth, it makes the breath smell bad. Behold here the effects of gluttony. Sixth, it makes the voice hoarse. Behold here the effects of anger. Seventh, it weakens all the members in their functioning. Behold here the sin of sloth.

Therefore the remedy, the cure, is to go to the Jordan, and the name comes from *Jor*, i.e. river, and *dan*, i.e. judgment. Behold here confession, which is nothing but the river of judgment. For there judgment of sins happen. Here, indeed, a man ought to get undressed, showing all his shames, i.e. naked sins, clearly, to the confessor. So he says "go", namely to the confessor, "to wash seven times", i.e. to confess the seven mortal sins to which all the other sins are

"There are some miserable people who choose not to confess their sins. If God had commanded us to hurl ourselves into a fire for the remission of sins, we should do it."

reduced. The first time man is washed of the sin of pride, in the second, of avarice, etc. In the seventh, however a man is clean and his face cleansed of all mortal stains, so that, having confessed, none remain to him.

There are some miserable people who choose not to confess their sins. If God had commanded us to hurl ourselves into a fire for the remission of sins, we should do it. How much more ought we confess, since it is so easy. Thus the servants said to Naaman, "If the prophet had bid you do some great thing, surely you should have done it. How much rather what he now has said to you: Wash, and you shall be clean?" (4 Kgs. 5:13). If it were possible, all of you ought to confess already today, that you might participate in the church's blessings. Thus John says, agreeing with the aforesaid image, "If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just, to forgive us our sins, and to cleanse us from all iniquity", (1 John 1:9). Now you know what you should be doing in this holy time of Lent.

Memento, homo, quia pulvis es, et in pulverem reverteris.

Remember, man, that thou art dust and unto dust thou shalt return.



NOTE FROM THE EDITOR

Welcome, dear Reader, to the sixth issue of *The Plough*.

We are in the Holy Season of Lent. Allow my note to be short.

Christendom starts with, and has for its end, sanctifying grace. While it is true that it is only the individual soul that goes before God at his personal judgement, it is also true that there is a corporate element to our salvation. The large majority of men in history, if they are in heaven, have those to thank whom God raised up to establish and defend public Christianity.

In the course of the ages, it has been Christian societies that secure Christian families, and it has been Christian families that secure Christian souls. We must work towards this goal because all things belong to Christ; each and every soul is part of His creation, while the social part of our nature is His creation too. This means that societies of men also belong to Him.

How do we achieve this? Is it necessary to become an individual saint before looking outside ourselves? Certainly not! Let not misguided rhetoric of inaction paralyse good

work. This rhetoric is comfortable because it precludes the difficult task of confronting the anti-Christ forces which seek to destroy all that is good in nature and the supernatural order entirely. God uses the humble, not the perfect, as His instruments. One did not need to be a living saint before going on crusade—perhaps it was the crusading that made the man a saint! However, it bears repeating, that we can and must be constantly guarding our own soul against mortal and habitual sin. After all, why give the devil any quarter? We will be vastly more efficient in our exterior efforts if our soul is kept pure. How could we claim to be protectors of sanctifying grace if we cannot keep it ourselves?

The Sacrament of Penance is the means that God has provided for our purification. Let us use this Lent to meditate upon, humbly consider, and repent for our sins, and resolve to renounce our evil for the glory of God and for His Will to be "done on earth as it is in heaven."

Thank you for your loyal patronage, dear Reader, and may God bless you,
Editor of *The Plough*.



The Spirit of '53

Industry or Humanity?

Ed Willock

From Integrity Magazine, 1953.

Scientific industrialism has induced a certain secular spirit which is a challenge to the spirit of Catholicism. The enormous increase in power and production made possible by scientific manufacture lends credence (presuming men are already irreligious) to the false hope that men are soon to shed the shackles of creatureliness. The machine has certainly augmented man's capacity for expansion and domination to a degree that would have tried the credibility of the medieval Catholic. This new found strength was discovered at a time when culture and religion were in decline. Consequently it has not been sufficiently observed that thanks to these scientific advances only a few of man's capabilities were amplified, while the whole man, rather than growing, actually diminished in stature.

The great shift of emphasis was this. Prior to automatic power men tended to identify human greatness with the state of being *subject* to authority; after its advent, human greatness came to be identified with man as the object of authority. Mechanical power increased our capacity for *doing*, it added nothing to our capacity for being. Human beatitude which once came as a result of freedom within imposed limitations was now sought as a freedom from all imposed limitations. Whereas Catholicism has always held that authority bestows blessings upon the subject, this new deceit sees authority as the source of limitations, hence an enemy of the human spirit.

"Unlimited Horizons"

The new spirit turns from all authority and limitations, and turns toward the machine which promises infinity. In this new dream of unlimited horizons each new labor-saving device is a promise of effortless existence. Each increase in "living standards" is a step toward inevitable paradise. Each new life-prolonging drug promises immortality. Each new speed record is a portent of omnipresence. This is no exaggeration. Consider the phrases with which these achievements are described and their enormous cost excused. "The abolition of drudgery"; is this not a description of preter-natural power? "The annihilation of

disease"; is this not immortality? "The annihilation of space"; is this not omnipresence, an attribute of God?

This language is not poetry, it is incantation. If it were merely ad-writers' exaggeration, how explain the millions and billions of dollars spent by corporations and governments on research and developments which scorn all reasonable limitations? Neither the immediate practical purpose nor the profit which accrues from its sale can account for the zealous pursuit of unlimited power. A certain few undoubtedly benefit from each new gadget and drug devised. The almost universal enthusiasm which results is no mere multiplication of various gratitudes. The social atmosphere is charged with the awareness that the machine promises unlimited horizons. It is the new savior not of one or two but of all mankind.

Were all this noise and commotion to a practical earthy purpose, would we not count the cost? Has any ledger been tabulated to prove, for example, that atomic power is actually worth the price it costs to release it? After all, you know, 50,000 men working for a half century for \$5,000 a year could not have raised enough money to buy the first atom bomb! Breaking the sound barrier has broken legions of men and cost incalculable toil. For what? For the same reason that we place no limit on incomes and no governors on the engines of automobiles. We have set no limit beyond which we will not go. Human life, human toil, human wealth is expendable in our search for this pearl of great price. The dream of unlimited horizons is the spirit of 1953 before which almost every knee bows. It is as prevalent in Russia as in America. It knows no borders.

Flight from Reality

Today's secular man is not as "materialistic" as we sometimes claim. He is not engrossed with matter as such. He is far less earthy, far less practical, far less of the husbandman than the ancient religious peasant. He delights not in the forest, nor does he revel in the fields. He is not in love with the material universe; he hasn't the capacity for such discernment. He has done something far less excusable and far more nasty; he has spiritualized matter.

He has melted down life into a soup of atoms and energy. He has divorced color from fabric. He separates sound from shape. He reduces all human ills to psychic disorders. TV and the movies shows his

preference for phantasms than for the company of men. He converts thumping convictions into eerie compulsions. He has peopled the earth with exceedingly dull ghosts. Far better, call him a "spiritist." Thank him for the fact that reality escapes us, leaving us to fight with shades and wrestle with the wind.

The Spirit of Catholicism

The spirit of Catholicism is not foreign to our times, nor has it ever been foreign to the affairs of man since the Incarnation. But this blithe spirit, the spirit of '53, could not have existed at any other time, nor will it live beyond the age that brought it into being. The Mass, the priesthood, the Papacy and the Sacraments are wholly contemporary. These will endure as long as man endures, as long as babies are born and old men die. Yet the contemporary challenge of unlimited horizons is an historical atmosphere in which Christians must live, and it is productive of social institutions which constitute a menace to the co-agents of the Church: the state, the family and the person.

For the sake of these things Catholics must be concerned. The spirit of Catholicism needs no defense. Its triumphal endurance is certain. But the social order, the city of man in which this spirit should become incarnated, currently is threatened by cancerous growths. It is in defense of these more fragile human things that the Popes have been speaking for the last century. We Catholics have listened with but one ear. Now the spirit of unlimited horizons has grown its own brood.

Mass Production

Mass production, as a social organization of men and machines, is the physical fact around which the dream of unlimited horizons is woven. Here is no wraith; here is a vibrant mass of flesh and metal, utterly tangible upon which we can focus our attention. Mass production is the very character, the heart-beat of the modern industrial enterprise.

Let us contrast what two modern thinkers have to say about the industrial enterprise. Perhaps in this way we can concretize all I have said previously about the Catholic versus the secular spirit.

Mr. Peter Drucker, writing in *Commonweal* (March 6, 1953) analyzes the modern enterprise much as he did in his book *The Enterprise* (a book, incidentally, written with the encouragement of the National Association of Manufacturers).

Pope Pius XII in his Christmas Eve address of last year warns us of the great illusion "which holds for certain that salvation must spring from the organization of men and things in a strict unity designed for the highest productive capacity."

Mr. Drucker tells us that "mass production is not a technological principle but primarily a new social order." As he goes on to describe it I can't help but wonder if this is not precisely the social order which Catholics were asked by their Pope almost a century ago to re-organize! Please note (as we did so many years ago in *Integrity*) that this is a social order, hence an order to which morality is directly relevant. It involves men, images of God.

Mr. Drucker further asserts: "In it (the industrial enterprise) we have the first autonomous institution that has emerged in Western society since the collapse of the medieval order... The enterprise is not a creature of the state—even though the laws which govern it and set its limitations are of course laws of the state." Now, this is interesting. No other institution can make such a claim! Here is an organization of

"Yet the contemporary challenge of unlimited horizons is an historical atmosphere in which Christians must live, and it is productive of social institutions which constitute a menace to the co-agents of the Church: the state, the family and the person."

men and machines that places itself on the same high plane as the Church and the human person. Neither God nor human society made it, and it though autonomous condescends to obey the state. Mr. Drucker didn't dare add, "will obey its laws whenever convenient." But this is implied throughout.

Indeed the enterprise "is the local-self-government of modern society." It will take the place of "manor, village, and town." It will do all this, mind you, despite the fact that "it cannot be governed primarily in the interest of the employees who are subject to its rules." The enterprise, as Mr. Drucker describes it, will thus usurp the local governing powers of the state, without accepting as primary the well-being of those so unfortunate as to comprise its citizenry.

Mr. Drucker brightly concedes that the federal government and labor unions can try to milk from this mammoth whatever is to the best interest of the public good and the worker, but it would be nonsense to pretend that the enterprise can be concerned with such altruism, unless it happens to be to its profit to do so. The government will also be useful in keeping these playful mammoths in order, just so they don't become unruly, as ambitious mammoths will ... ha, ha.

Technical Concept of Society

Mr. Drucker presents all this without apology, as though he were in no way violating the social principles by which men have lived for centuries. The nature of man and society apparently are irrelevant in the face of this "new social order."

On the other hand Pius XII tells us that "one knows where to look in social thought for the technical concept of society, namely, in the gigantic enterprises of modern industry. We do not intend here to express an opinion on the necessity, utility and disadvantages of these forms of production. Indubitably, they are marvelous manifestations of the inventive and constructive genius of the human spirit. It is right for the world to admire enterprises which in the area of production and management succeed in co-ordinating and mobilizing the physical forces of men and matter. And the present age may take legitimate pride in the stable way in which enterprises are organized and in the often novel and characteristic beauty of their external set-up. But what must be denied is that modern social life should be regulated by them or made to conform to them."

Has not our excusable admiration turned to adoration when we can conceive of these brute forces displacing the family, towering over political society, consuming society all for the sake of an oily omnipotence?



Cotton mill chimneys belching smoke in Manchester, England, 1936.